Augustus Saalfeld

Writing samples

1. Designing a feedback system for Dietrich College’s DEI office 2
2. Barista training manual 23
3. What happens when you type youtube.com into the web browser? 30
4. Adding a new course export feature to Canvas 37
5. How to grow oyster mushrooms at home 44
6. Short stories and research on computer science fiction 49

Dietrich College Dean's
Office of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

Executive Summary

Community Partner
Ayana Ledford
Student Consulting Team
Gloria Moon
Neha Choudhari
Augustus Saalfeld

Background

The mission of the Dietrich College Dean's Office of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) is to "provide oversight on diversity, equity and inclusion issues and facilitates communication and accountability". The associate dean monitors DEI initiatives within the larger Dietrich ecosystem, which is the second-largest academic body at CMU. Consequently, they reach a large audience that spans across undergraduate students, graduate students, faculty, and staff. The DEI system relies on shared responsibility, making it decentralized and dynamic. Individual departments, with the help of volunteers, launch and monitor their own DEI initiatives, such as workshops, guest lectures, and town hall meetings.

Project Description

Project Opportunity

The biggest challenge the Dietrich DEI committee faces is collecting, storing, and accessing committee data in a centralized format. As a team, it was our job to use our stakeholder interviews to determine which of DEI's pain points to address in our solution. We decided on the data pain point, because the Dietrich Dean's Office of DEI cannot accurately assess impact without first establishing a more efficient and organized system for collecting data on DEI initiatives. Many departments did not collect post-event data, and emailing volunteers to collect it was time consuming. Being decentralized, it is difficult to work with DEI data aggregated across Dietrich.

Project Vision

The biggest pain point that Ayana said she faced was getting a broad picture view of DEI initiatives across Dietrich. In particular, our client found it difficult to collect post-event data on each department's DEI initiatives. To combat this, we proposed to build a standardized form for her to send out to department heads via email. The form saves on time by streamlining the data-collection process. Then, the data can automatically be stored in a single spreadsheet shared across Google Drive. A labeled, accessible spreadsheet could also make Ayana develop visualizations to explore trends in the data.

Project Outcomes

The main project outcomes were developing a method for Ayana to collect and store programmatic data about DEI initiatives. From a technology standpoint, we developed a Google Form, Google Spreadsheet, and Tableau Dashboard to visualize form responses. This new technology greatly improved Ayana's communication process with department heads and administrators, as before she would manually email all for basic event data. Throughout these past few months our team also developed a strong relationship with Ayana as we met every Wednesday in person. With a strong, trustworthy relationship, we were able to work together to iterate our Google Form solution and understand our respective viewpoints.

Project Deliverables

Our group's final deliverable was a finalized Google Form that is now published and live on the CMU Dietrich DEI website. In addition, this form was attached to a Google Spreadsheet with form responses, as well as a Tableau dashboard showing overall event trends as well as departmental trends. Our solution targets capturing event information (such as description, primary goals), and event statistics (such as number of attendees, number of people who RSVP'd). Lastly, we created documentation to help sustain a long-term solution, including a solution guide, user testing script, and our research findings.

Recommendations

To maintain a successful solution, we recommended: continue to have the form capture success metrics to support the strategic plan; leverage the system of people accountable to the form in case its frequency of use goes down; consider implementing an incentive system.

To further develop the form/tableau solution, we recommended: create more tableau visualizations; create attendee post-event survey form; create automated mailer that notifies event organizer to fill out form.

Student Consulting Team

Gloria Moon served as the project manager, leading the team to success with high-quality deliverables. She is a junior majoring in Information Systems and Human-Computer Interaction with a minor in Media Design. She will be a PM intern in Seattle this summer and is pursuing a career in product management.

Neha Choudhari is a junior at Carnegie Mellon pursuing a degree in Information Systems with an additional major in Statistics/Machine Learning. This summer, she will be working in Seattle as a software engineer. In her free time, she enjoys web development and playing the flute. In this project, she was the client relationship manager.

Gus Saalfeld worked as the documentation manager, helping the client sustain a long-term solution. He is a senior Creative Writing & Information Systems double major. This summer, he is pursuing software engineering and game development positions.

Final Report

04.29.2022

Team Pangolin: Gloria Moon, Neha Choudhari, Augustus Saalfeld
Client: Dietrich College Dean's Office of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion
Client Contact: Ayana Ledford (Associate Dean for DEI)

Table of Contents

Table of Contents	**1**
Community Partner Background	**2**
Community Partner Project Opportunity	**2**
Project Outcomes	**4**
Final Project Deliverables	**6**
Recommendations	**7**
About the Team	**8**
Appendix A: Sketches and Work on the Information Flowchart	**9**
Appendix B: Screenshots of the Tableau Dashboard	**11**
Appendix C: Google Form	**13**
Citations	**13**

Community Partner Background

The mission of the Dietrich College Dean's Office of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) is to "*provide oversight on diversity, equity and inclusion issues and facilitates communication and accountability*" [1]. The office consults an advisory committee and an implementation committee [2], with both parties working together to bring inclusion to community programs, events, and resources. They monitor DEI initiatives within the larger Dietrich ecosystem, which is the second-largest academic body at CMU. Consequently, they reach a large audience that spans across undergraduate students, graduate students, faculty, and staff [3]. Their active goals and objectives are outlined in their Strategic Plan, available on the Dietrich DEI website.

The DEI system relies on shared responsibility, making it decentralized and dynamic. Individual departments launch and monitor their own DEI initiatives, such as workshops, guest lectures, and town hall meetings. These initiatives are organized by part-time volunteers within the department. No enforceable standard existed to tell departments what data to capture, or whether to employ success metrics.

Community Partner Project Opportunity

Project Opportunity

The biggest challenge the Dietrich DEI committee faces is collecting, storing, and accessing committee data in a centralized format. Currently, when events and initiatives are led by committees, there is no defined way for them to forward data such as attendance to our community partner Ayana's office. Ayana often reaches out to the different departments in Dietrich herself to gather the data, which has proven to be extremely inefficient and time-consuming. DEI's structure extends across multiple departments, making it hard to enforce data collection standards.

Establishing a more efficient and organized system for collecting data on DEI initiatives is important because otherwise, the Dietrich College Dean's Office of DEI cannot accurately assess impact. They could not determine how well the programs are doing nor what programs are happening within separate departments. They are missing the opportunity to collect crucial data and to measure the success of all their hard work.

DEI would greatly benefit from a technology solution that allows committees to easily store data, describe their events, and allows our client to instantly view and organize said data. By having a single source for DEI data, tools like Tableau can be utilized to seamlessly create graphics to post to the public. By monitoring trends in the data library, Ayana and the Dietrich College dean would know what works best for implementing DEI efforts in Dietrich College.

Project Vision

Essentially, our proposed project vision was to improve the speed of data collection and data storing within the DEI department.

The biggest pain point that Ayana said she faced was getting a broad picture view of DEI initiatives across Dietrich. It was difficult to find a list of all ongoing DEI events. She had to manually reach out to department heads to ask for relevant post-event data. Such

data is not standardized, not easy to compile/visualize, and is often lost in long email chains. To combat this, we proposed building a standardized form for her to send out to department heads via email. After interviewing stakeholders across Dietrich, we found that our solution addressed four broad pain points: low data-sharing; lack of communication between departments on DEI initiatives; need for improved planning visibility; and motivating volunteers. After filling out the form, the data is automatically stored in a single spreadsheet shared over Google Drive. Using Tableau, our client can develop this into graphics visualizing the state of Dietrich DEI. For example, a pie chart breaking down the number of events by department.

- Value: This solution directly addresses the main pain point that Ayana faces, which is slow communication. Sending a form link, as opposed to taking time to curate questions and then send them over, will reduce the amount of time it takes Ayana to communicate with department heads. Likewise, a pipeline that transfers form data to a spreadsheet will reduce the amount of time it takes for Ayana to compile the data into a place other than her email. A simple Google Drive folder containing the form, responses, and a compiled spreadsheet will allow Ayana to interpret and visualize the data however she wishes to. The main stakeholders for this solution include the department heads, who will benefit from a standardized form with pre-defined data to collect, and Ayana/Dietrich deans, who would now have a centralized area to view data and potentially visualize it.
- Alternate Solution: A possible alternate solution to helping the DEI team with data collection/storage is building a database from scratch, and having department heads enter information directly into it so no emails are sent at all. Though this is probably the most efficient solution for time, it is not feasible for many reasons. Firstly, Ayana emphasized that the department heads are not tech-savvy, and are most comfortable with sending information and communicating via email and Google Suite. Additionally, a custom-built application would require constant maintenance and bug fixes, which would likely be burdensome for Ayana or the CMU IT department.

Project Outcomes

Tools that our team used to develop our technological solution mostly included Tableau and Google Drive. We developed a Google form to Excel spreadsheet pipeline whose responses were available for dynamic Tableau visualizations. See the form and its flowchart in the appendix, figures 5 & 9. The most important feature of this solution was the ability for Ayana to have a centralized space for DEI initiative data. Though we did not develop entirely new technology, we expanded on the ones that Ayana frequently used to communicate with fellow department heads or administrators. Capturing data by form has standardized the data being received, allowing Ayana to compare data points across departments. In addition, the questions will motivate departments to think critically about success metrics and the benefits of implementing data-driven initiatives. The form can be found on the Dietrich DEI website: https://www.cmu.edu/dietrich/about/dei/index.html.

The Dietrich DEI department agreed to use our form to implement a new rewards program, helping motivate volunteers to fill it out. We knew our form would soon fall out of

use without a motivation system. To support this, we brainstormed with our client one person within each department who would be accountable for implementation. Dietrich's senior administrative coordinator will send this list a monthly email, prompting them to fill out the form. Ayana can use this email list to easily communicate with those implementing the form within each department.

The Tableau dashboard has three pages, one shows a summary view of Dietrich, one shows visualizations of the departments and the last shows visualizations regarding each goal. Visualizations include a pie chart broken-down by each DEI initiative's primary objective. Ayana can use these visualizations to identify successful initiatives, departments, or event types. See Appendix B.

In order to have the final outcome of our solution being an official Dietrich data collecting device, we did have to abide by the CMU design guidelines. This included changing the title to include "CMU," making the form dark red, and adding a plaid banner. With regards to how the form was to be distributed to all the DEI departments, our intended outcome was for it to reach as many people as possible. This outcome was achieved as we published the form on the Dietrich DEI official website (https://www.cmu.edu/dietrich/about/dei/index.html). This configuration makes the form accessible to any volunteer or DEI committee member who held an event and would like to relay its information to Ayana. The Tableau visualizations and Google Spreadsheet were only shared with Ayana due to privacy and confidentiality concerns, but this configuration may change as Ayana develops them further after handoff.

In addition to configuring the Google Form aesthetically to fit CMU's image, we conducted several rounds of user testing to ensure that our product was tailored to DEI stakeholders. The user testing expanded Dietrich DEI's capacity by tailoring the form to maximize clarity, efficiency, and value. We asked them about the form's readability and accessibility. One change we made through user testing was adding initiative goal descriptions, so users had a better idea of which bucket their initiative fit into. We had our client validate our initial Google Form before proceeding with development, along with a flowchart visualizing the form's sequence of questions. As the form evolved, we kept her informed by bringing an updated copy to meetings. We user-tested in two phases. In the first phase, we used our first iteration of the form and asked DEI stakeholders to think aloud as they filled out the form for any initiative they have been related to in the past. Similarly, we did the same thing with the second batch of user testers after we altered the form according to feedback. User testing ensured that our product was configured to our user's abilities and expectations.

In addition, we created handover documentation to help the client maintain a sustainable product. The documentation describes the form, how to make edits to it, a system of contact information for people responsible for maintaining the solution, and a list of suggestions for how to improve the form. Our client has read and understands the documentation, improving their capacity to perform these tasks. Another document summarizes our key research findings, documenting all of the key stakeholders and organizations as well as advice on anyone working within Dietrich DEI. We also included a script for testing changes on users, and a video to quickly introduce the form.

We successfully established a solid system of people accountable to our solution. Ayana is the product owner, responsible for changing the form or visualizations if

necessary. We have two people in the IT & Operations department who have agreed to implement Ayana's changes. Each was introduced to the solution. Our client has the capacity to implement changes, and clearly knows who she can ask to do what. When interviewing stakeholders across Dietrich, we also clearly explained the form's purpose over email and in-person. This, as well as introducing the form to the implementation committee, laid the groundwork for implementing the form across all departments.

The main top-level outcome is that Ayana will save countless hours of emailing departments for data and compiling the data they send. The form will no longer have to be emailed to event administrators, as it is on the home page of the DEI website, and their responses will be automatically updated on Ayana's Google Spreadsheet. In addition to this top-level outcome, Ayana's ability to track trends of DEI initiatives can substantially improve the future of Dietrich DEI. Ayana can now have empirical data (and visualizations) as evidence for what events were successful and can have a good understanding of what kinds of events work best for students. Departments also have more of an incentive to hold department-wide DEI initiatives because of the introduction of awards Ayana is distributing. Overall, the top-level outcomes benefit Ayana and the analysis of DEI events.

Final Project Deliverables

- Google Form
  - Final Google Form - "CMU Dietrich DEI Post-Event Data Collection Form" is accessible in the main folder. Any data collected with appear here.
  - Final Google Spreadsheet - "CMU Dietrich DEI Post-Event Data Collection Form" also displays real-time collected data in one space.
  - Previous iterations - Can be found in the "Google Form Iterations" folder.

- Information Flowchart
  - Final Information Flowchart - "Information Flowchart" is accessible in the main folder. It represents the final Google Form in a clean, visual way.
  - Previous iterations - Can be found in the "Information Flowchart Iterations" folder.

- Tableau Dashboard
  - Final Tableau Dashboard - "final_dashboard.twb" is accessible in the Tableau Dashboard folder. Once opened with Tableau, it will display all the dashboards and visualizations when the data source is connected properly.
  - Screenshots - screenshots of the dashboard is accessible in the Tableau Dashboard folder.

- Documentation
  - User Testing Script - "Default User Testing Script" is accessible in the documentation folder.
  - Documentation Guide - "Guide to the Dietrich DEI Post-Event Data Collection Form" is accessible in the documentation folder.
  - Interview Findings - "Research Findings on Dietrich DEI" is accessible in the documentation folder.

- Evidence of Website Integration
    - “Evidence of Website Integration” is accessible in the main folder.
- Pitch Video
    - “pitch_video.mp4” is accessible in the main folder.

Recommendations

Sustaining the solution's capacity depends on maintaining volunteer motivation and ensuring the form stays relevant. Departments and volunteers must be motivated to continue filling out the form. Our client can incentivize them by further pursuing a program that rewards departments for hosting events and then logging them through the form. In addition, our client will have to leverage the system of people accountable to the form in case its frequency of use goes down. In terms of keeping the form relevant, we advise reviewing it after each new strategic plan is released. The form is a great way to support the strategic plan's goals with success metrics.

As included in the handover documentation, the following is a list of recommendations for how to increase DEI's capacity. For one, you could create a post-event survey for event organizers to send out to attendees. The results of this survey could be added as a link in the form. Dietrich DEI could then capture self-reported data from attendees, as well as further gauge the success of events. Success could be linked to metrics derived from the strategic plan. To create this form, a team should repeat our development process. They should 1. interview the DEI dean to determine what data points they need 2. interview various stakeholders including individuals who already sent out post-event surveys 3. have the client validate an initial prototype 4. iterate through user-testing.

Another recommendation would be to create an automated mailer linked to CMU's event calendar. After the event has passed on the calendar, this mailer could automatically email the event coordinator, reminding them to fill out our form. This extension assumes all/most events are uploaded to CMU's event calendar. After interviewing whoever runs CMU's event calendar, a team could develop an automated bot that would email the coordinator. A reminder to fill out the form sent at the right time will improve the percentage of people who do so.

Our final recommendation would be to increase data visibility. Our client could create more visualizations; integrate visualizations into CMU's website; and make data easily accessible to the wider DEI community, allowing them to analyze it for themselves. For example, Tableau could be used to visualize the scorecards found in the strategic plan. These scorecards could be integrated directly into the strategic plan's page. Making more visualizations, and making them more accessible, increases the collected data's value.

To another IS group working within Dietrich DEI, we would advise them on the importance of interviewing a wide range of stakeholders. Dietrich is a broad space, and sometimes two stakeholders had very different opinions on the same subject. Given the number of people within Dietrich, we would also highly recommend rigorous user testing to strengthen your solution. They should also understand that because DEI is volunteer-based, motivation is key and the solution must be compelling.

About the Team

Gloria Moon served as the project manager, leading the team to success with high-quality deliverables. She is a junior majoring in Information Systems and Human-Computer Interaction with a minor in Media Design. She will be a PM intern in Seattle this summer and is pursuing a career in product management.

Neha Choudhari is a junior at Carnegie Mellon pursuing a degree in Information Systems with an additional major in Statistics/Machine Learning. This summer, she will be working in Seattle as a software engineer. In her free time, she enjoys web development and playing the flute.

Gus Saalfeld worked as the documentation manager, synthesizing the team's best practices and research findings to help the client sustain a long-term solution. He is a senior Creative Writing and Information Systems double major. This summer, he is pursuing software engineering and game development positions and will be hiking the Pacific Coast Trail.

Appendix A: Sketches and Work on the Information Flowchart

Figure 1: First Sketch from Ayana

This clarified ideas and the structure of the Google Form in one of our early meetings.

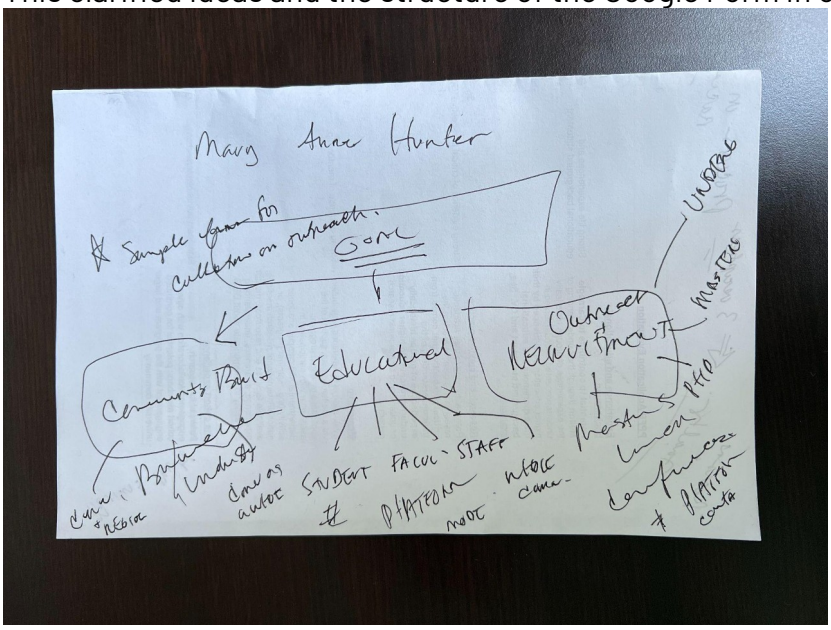


Figure 2: First Sketch from Team

The team then created a sketch based on Ayana's work. This served as a model for the first Google Form.

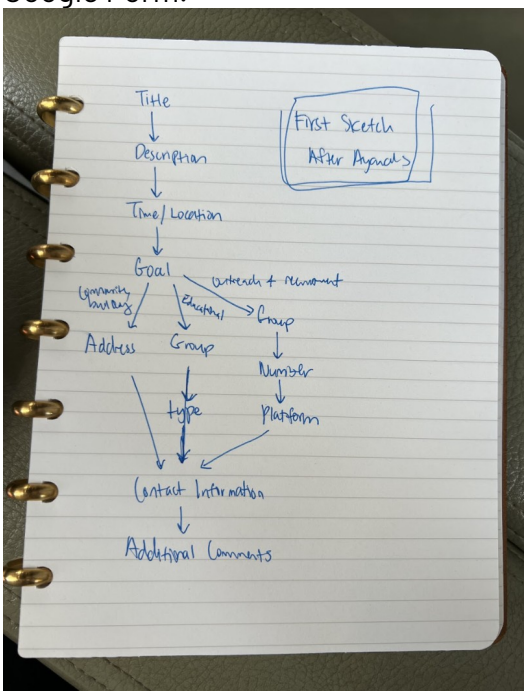


Figure 3: Second Sketch from Ayana

The team printed out the Information Flowchart and reviewed the design with the client in the next client meeting. Ayana commented and suggested areas for improvement.

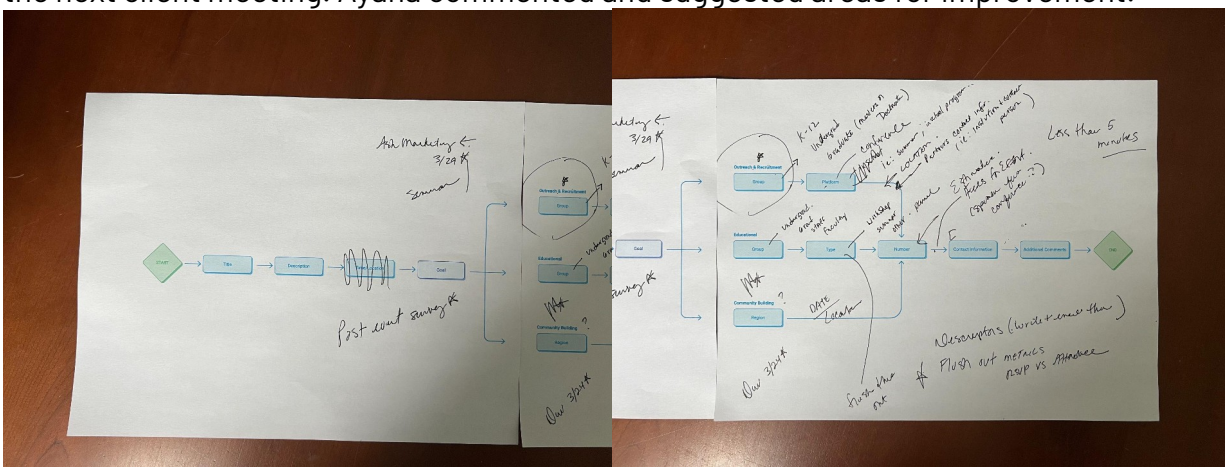


Figure 4: Team Meeting
Reviewed progress on the very last iteration of the Information Flowchart during a meeting.

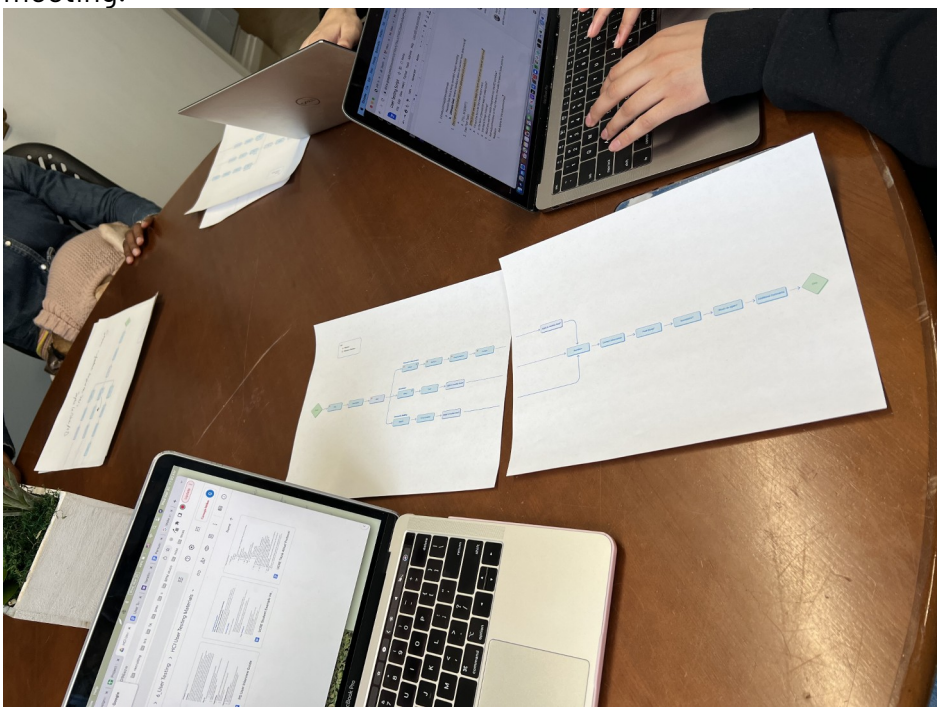
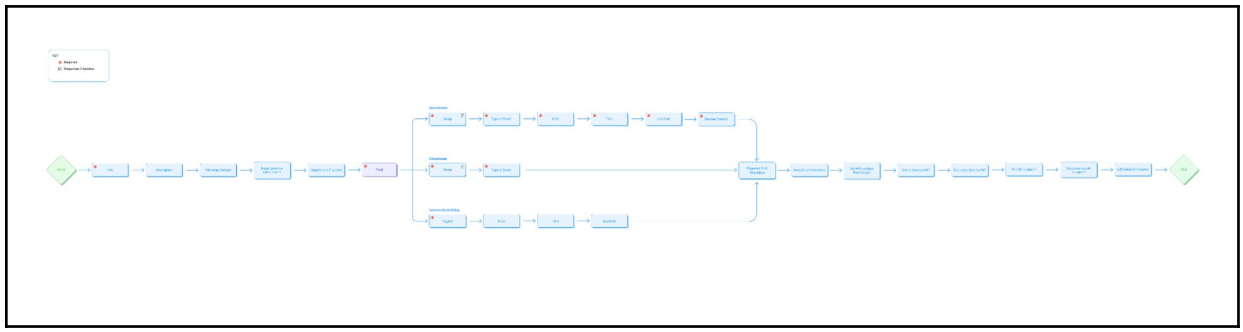


Figure 5: Final Flowchart
The Final Flowchart that visually represents the Google Form solution.



Appendix B: Screenshots of the Tableau Dashboard

Figure 6: Tableau Dashboard 1 - Overall
The main Tableau Dashboard that displays overall information on events and attendance.

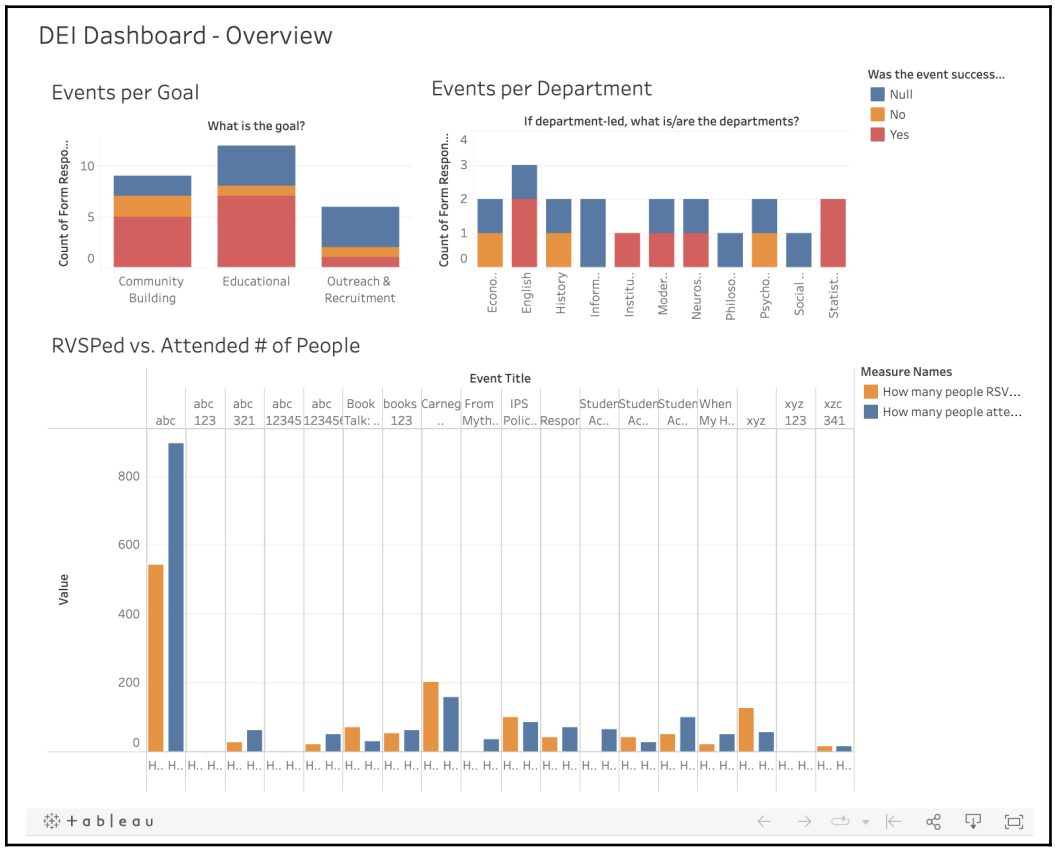


Figure 7: Tableau Dashboard 2 - Departments
The Tableau Dashboard that displays detailed information on departments and events.

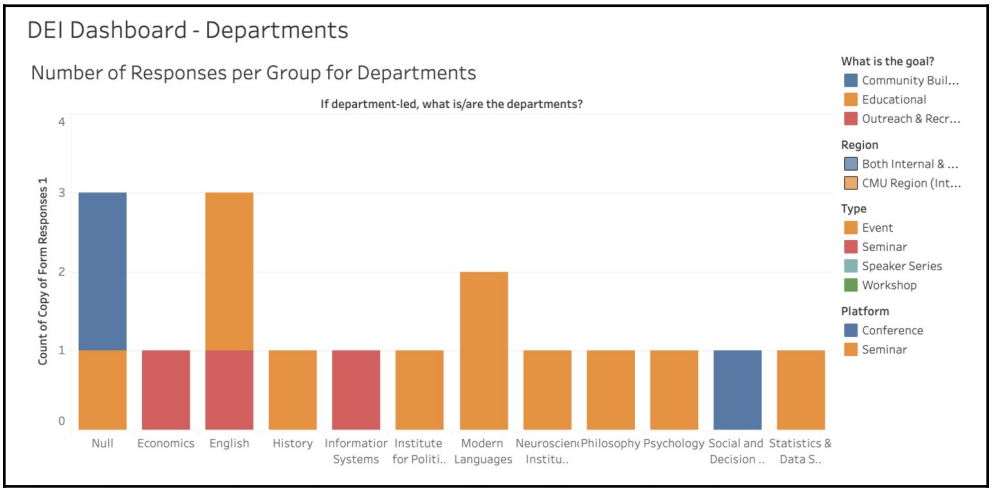
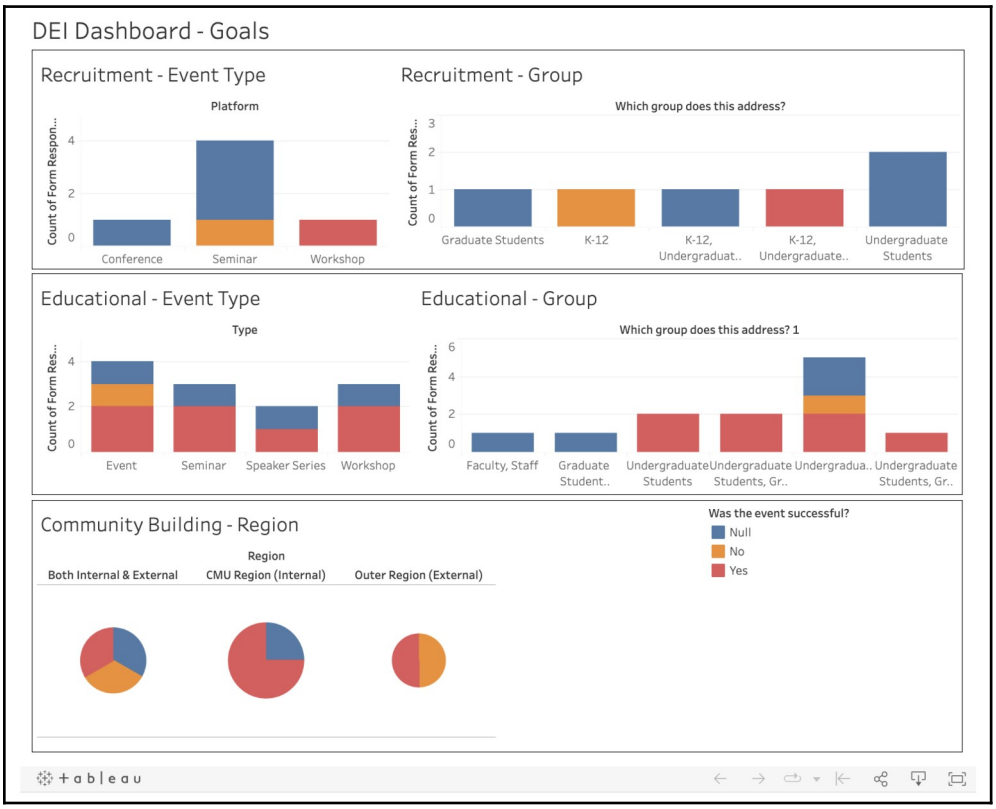


Figure 8: Tableau Dashboard 3: Goals

The Tableau Dashboard that displays detailed information on goals and events.



Appendix C: Google Form

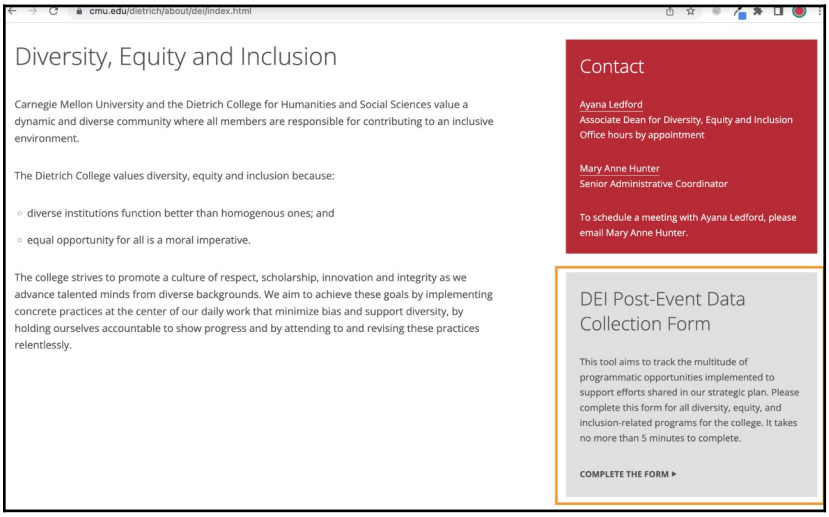
Figure 9: Final Google Form

The Final Google Form solution.



Figure 10: Evidence of Website Integration

A screenshot of the official CMU page where the Google Form is hosted.



Citations

1. https://www.cmu.edu/dietrich/about/dei/index.html
2. https://www.cmu.edu/dietrich/about/dei/committees.html
3. https://www.cmu.edu/dietrich/about/dei/strategic-plan.html
4. https://www.cmu.edu/diehttps://www.cmu.edu/dietrich/about/dei/strategic-plan.htmltrich/about/dei/docs/diversity-equity-inclusion-strategic-plan.pdf

Table of Contents

Introduction: **1**

Google Form Flowchart: 2

Accessing the Google Form: 2

Technology Involved: 2

Tips For Updating the Google Form: 3

Suggestions on how to extend the product: 3

Product Roles: 4

Excel/Google Sheets Guide: 4

Tableau Guide: 4

Introduction:

In the past, the associate dean of Dietrich DEI found it difficult to build a big picture understanding of DEI events within Dietrich. DEI's decentralized structure meant that many departments did not proactively share data they collected on their DEI events, while other departments did not collect data at all. The associate dean needed to individually email each department for their data.

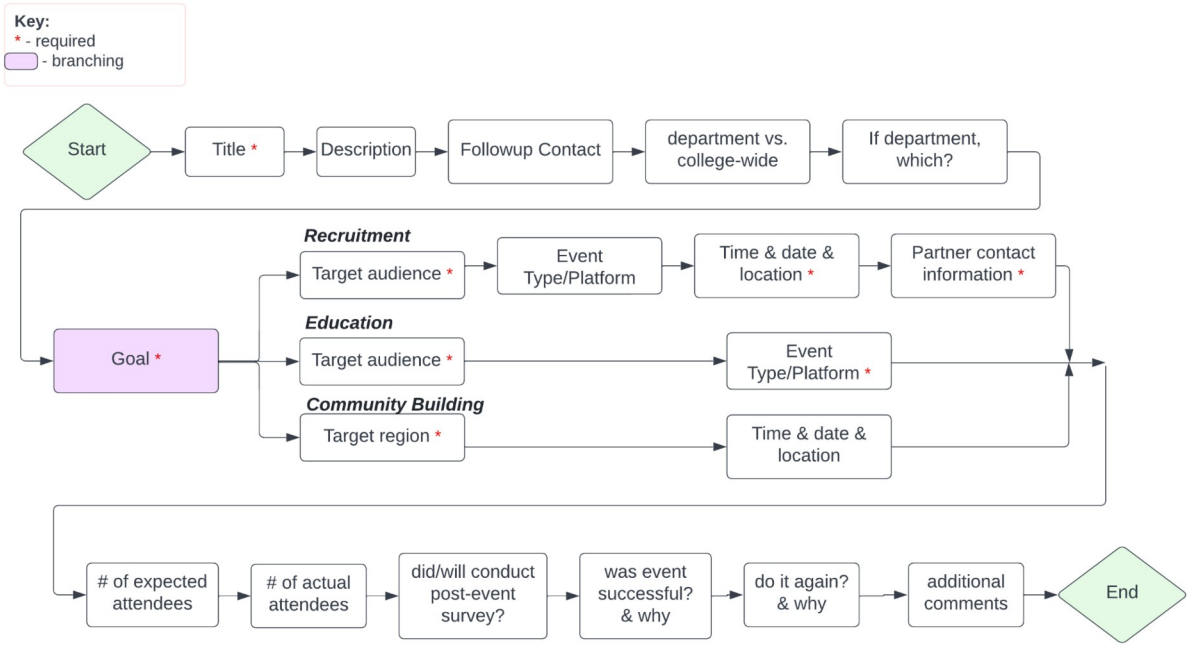
The DEI post-event form replaces these long email chains with a standardized data collection process, feeding into a single google spreadsheet. The form saves time, simplifies communication, and eliminates tedious labor. The data captured by the form supports much of DEI's strategic plan, and encourages data-driven decision-making when it comes to planning future DEI initiatives.

As of **spring 2021**, this form supports four goals, four strategies, and two indicators listed in the DEI strategic plan. The following goals are taken from the plan. These are:

- **Goal:** "Create reporting mechanisms to communicate the status of the college's DEI initiatives"
- **Goal:** "Host departmental and college-wide events that center on diversity, equity and inclusion, as well as provide opportunities for administration and students to interface."
    - DEI organizers can filter data to examine the success of college-wide versus department level events. In addition, they can better assess the success of individual departments.
- **Goal:** "Provide an equitable and inclusive environment for graduate students."
    - *Strategy A (i.e. Data collection):* "While we can make some initial inferences about climate, more data collection is needed to ascertain the particularities of how graduate students in Dietrich College experience their education at CMU, institutional policies and resources and climate community."
    - *Strategy C success indicator:* Form will help collect ""annual college-wide events per goals."
    - *Solution supports related success indicator:* Event database will help inform "long-term assessment of implemented strategies on a case-by-case basis."

- **Goal: “**Creating Diversity @ Dietrich”
    - *Strategy A:* Our form will simplify sharing “the attendance at events” with DEI. By capturing all events in a single google sheet, Diversity@Dietrich can be improved by comparing it to similar DEI initiatives.

Google Form Flowchart:



Accessing the Google Form:

There are two ways to access the link to the google form:

- On the DEI website: https://www.cmu.edu/dietrich/about/dei/index.html
- After an event, an admin such as Mary Anne Hunter, a business manager, or Associate Dean Ayana Ledford should email the event coordinator a link to the form.

Technology Involved:

- Google forms
- Google sheets - stores the data
- Tableau - helps visualize the data

Tips For Updating the Google Form:

If you make changes to the google form, then be sure to:

- Maintain the standard question format whenever possible. Here are a list of formatting rules:
    - Clear questions:
        - Clear nouns: e.g. instead of “title,” which could be interpreted in multiple ways, write “Event title.”
        - When appropriate, use full sentences.
        - When appropriate, define terms/concepts which might be unfamiliar to volunteers.
    - Required questions should have “(required)” added to their title.
    - Questions should be punctuated by a question mark.
- Try to user test those changes on DEI volunteers before making changes to the live form. User testing helps maintain a clear and effective solution.
    - *Link to user testing script:* https://docs.google.com/document/d/1Uv1STXrzZcdSTmyQGwka8jT-g90rTHT2Pbg3-s-PUMY/edit?usp=sharing
- Every Dietrich DEI event should promote one of three primary goals: recruitment, education, or community building. For each goal, we capture different data points. As can be seen in the updated flowchart, the form branches depending on what volunteers select for “what is the goal?.” For example, checking the recruitment field will take the volunteer to the recruitment section.
    - **Parity:** Goal sections capture some of the same data points. For example, both the educational and recruitment sections contain the question, “Which group does this address?.” When you change a question, check that that question doesn’t also need to be updated in other goal sections. Question parity ensures we can more easily compare data points between goals.
- Be mindful of bloat! The more questions you add, the less likely volunteers might be to fill out the form.

Suggestions on how to extend the product:

- As the strategic plan evolves, add new questions to the form to capture supporting data points.
- Create a post-event survey for event organizers to send out to attendees. Will allow us to capture self-reported data from attendees, as well as further gauge the success of events.
- Create an automated mailer linked to CMU’s event calendar. After the event has passed on the calendar, automatically email the event coordinator, reminding them to fill out our form. This extension assumes all/most events are uploaded to the calendar.
- Increase data visibility: Create more visualizations; integrate visualizations into the website; make raw data easily accessible to the wider DEI community, allowing them to analyze it for themselves.
    - e.g. Use tableau to visualize the scorecards found in the strategic plan.

Product Roles:

Product Owner: (responsible for fielding questions, devising updates for the forms, and extending the solution.)
Ayana Ledford - Associate Dean of Dietrich DEI [redacted]

Form & Google Sheets Admin: (responsible for implementing changes to the google form.)
Nicole Mitchell - H&SS Web [redacted]

Tableau Admin: (*responsible for implementing changes to tableau visualizations.*)
George Cann - [redacted]

D-list & Point-of-contact Accountability Manager (*responsible for maintaining dlist and, once a month, emailing users accountable for implementing form within their department.*)
Mary Anne Hunter - [redacted]

Excel/Google Sheets Guide:

Google Sheets
The responses for the Google Form will be available in the same folder as the Google Form, called 'CMU Dietrich DEI Post-Event Data Collection Form Responses". Here are some notable actions to take with the Google Spreadsheet if you'd like to conduct further data analysis:

- File -> Share/Email/Download can redirect you to send the spreadsheet to other users
    - If opened in Microsoft Excel, visualizations can be made by dragging relevant data and clicking Insert -> Recommended Charts
- Format tab can tailor the spreadsheet to any aesthetic design you prefer

Cells and rows can be selected similar to Excel spreadsheets. For any information on the Google Sheets capabilities, please visit https://support.google.com/a/users/answer/9310369?hl=en#:~:text=With%20Google%20Sheets%2C%20you%20can,every%20change%20is%20saved%20automatically.

Tableau Guide:

Tableau

There are **2** Tableau dashboards available that display visualizations related to the Google Form responses.

Overall Dashboard:
The overall dashboard contains 3 visualization, with two visualizations at the top and one large one underneath. The descriptions are as follows:

- Events per Goal
    - This graphic displays the number of successful events in the Dietrich DEI space for each goal [Recruitment, Educational, Community Building]
- Events per Department
    - This graphic displays the number of successful events in the Dietrich DEI space for each department
- Expected vs. Attended # of People
    - This graphic compares the number of expected to attended people at all events.

Department Dashboard:
The department dashboard contains 4 visualizations, with one large visualization at the top and 3 smaller visualizations underneath. The descriptions are as follows:

- Number of Responses per Group for Departments
    - This graphic depicts all the Deitrich departments on the x-axis with their associated number of form responses
- Community Building: Departments and Regions Reached
    - This graphic displays the number of form responses for the community building goal per department, colored by the region it was targeted for.
- Education: Departments and Types of Events
    - This graphic displays the number of form responses for the education goal per department, colored by the type of event it was (workshop, speaker series, etc).
- Outreach and Recruitment: Departments and Platforms of Events
    - This graphic displays the number of form responses for the outreach/recruitment goal per department, colored by the type of platform it was held on (Seminar, conference, etc)

Goals Dashboard:
The goals dashboard contains 5 visualizations in total, all focused on the goals in DEI.

- Recruitment
    - Number of Successful Events per Event Type
    - Number of successful Events per Group
- Educational
    - Number of Successful Events per Event Type
    - Number of successful Events per Group
- Community Building
    - Number of Successful Events per Region

A New Barista's Guide to Making the Perfect Hot 16 oz Double Latte

Version: 1.0 Effective Date: 6/13/2026

Purpose:

This guide will teach you how to make a hot 16 oz double latte at La Prima's CMU locations. Making a latte will teach you how to use an espresso machine for the first time. In four steps, you will learn how to make a latte that satisfies La Prima's commitment to traditional Italian coffee-making. Reviewing this guide regularly will improve your process.

Scope:

This guide is meant for new baristas working at the Gates and Wean locations on CMU's campus. Other La Prima locations do things a little differently, so be sure to ask your supervisor if you work at Oakland, the AC, or the Strip.

Procedure:

1. Preparing the cup:

Whoever is working the register will take customers' orders and write them down on a cup in the form of a short-hand cup code. They will place this cup on the drink counter.

Each drink on our menu has a unique cup code. The cup code will also include modifications to the customer's drink, such as syrups, decaf espresso, and milk substitutes. You can find a guide to cup codes on top of the pastry cart.

1. We use a first-in, first-out method when processing orders. That means we fulfill the orders in the order that we get them. Typically, this means you need to grab the cup nearest to you on the drink counter first.
2. Read the cup code to figure out what drink to make as well as any modifications it might have. If it is a paper cup, make a hot drink. If it is a plastic cup, make an iced drink. Some examples:
    a. A hot 16 oz double latte with whole milk would be written as 2L on a 16 oz paper cup.
    b. An iced 20 oz double latte with oat milk and vanilla syrup would be written as 2Loatv on a 20 oz plastic cup.
3. Read the cup code to determine if the customer wants any syrups in their drink. The number of pumps you add depends on the type of syrup and the size of the drink. If the customer requests a specific amount of syrup, the person on register will specify the number of pumps on the cup.
    a. Be consistent when pumping the syrup bottle. Push the pump all the way down each time you pump. Replace the bottle when it is nearing empty or it will pump inconsistently.

Default number of pumps of syrup per drink size:

8 oz drink	12 oz drink	16 oz drink	20 oz iced drink
1 pump	2 pumps	3 pumps	4 pumps

Default number of pumps of chai per drink size:

8 oz drink	12 oz drink	16 oz drink	20 oz iced drink
3.5 pump	4 pumps	5 pumps	6 pumps

2. Preparing the espresso:

On your first day, your supervisor will show you each part of the espresso machine: the buttons, portafilters, group heads, and steam wands. When you press the single or double espresso button, hot water pours out of the espresso machine, through the puck of ground beans in your portafilter, and comes out as espresso. Expensive espresso machines use high water pressure to extract flavor and caffeine. This high pressure tops your shot of espresso with cream (or "crema" in Italian). "Crema" is a mixture of sugar, coffee oils, and carbon dioxide.

To make an Italian-style double latte, first pour two shots of espresso into a 16 oz cup, then fill the rest with steamed milk. We call pouring a shot of espresso "pulling a shot." Here's how:

1. Remove a double shot portafilter from the espresso machine. A double shot portafilter has two spouts and a deeper basket than a single shot portafilter. If the portafilter is dirty, clean it with the rag on top of the espresso grinder.
2. For a double latte, put your portafilter under the grinder and press the double espresso button. There are two grinders: one is caffeinated, the other is decaf.
    a. If the latte is decaf, be sure to use the decaf grinder. Serving caffeine to a customer who requests decaf could put their health at risk.
3. Put the portafilter full of ground beans on the rubber tamping mat. Tamp the coffee in your portafilter down into a hockey shaped puck. Avoid over tamping or under tamping your puck. You only need to press down firmly enough to flatten the surface of the puck.

Espresso puck is tamped down perfectly.	Espresso puck is not tamped down enough.	Espresso puck is overly tamped down.
Surface is even.	Surface is often loose and uneven.	Surface is tight and compact.
Hot water extracts coffee from puck evenly, leading to good	Hot water will find path of least resistance through puck, leading to	Hot water will take too long to move through the puck, leading to

espresso.	watery espresso.	overly bitter espresso.

4. Put your cup beneath the group head you plan to screw your portafilter into. Group heads are the holes on the top of the espresso machine from which the hot water comes out.
5. Use your hand to wipe off any coffee grounds on the top of your portafilter. Avoid using the tamp for this, as it will crack your puck.
6. Screw your portafilter into a group head with a clockwise turn. There are two double shot buttons above each portafilter. Press the button to the left of the portafilter, as that is the one that supervisors calibrate regularly. This is known as “dialing in” a group head. A dialed in group head guarantees a consistent outcome: 1oz of well-extracted espresso per shot.
7. Watch the espresso as it pours into the cup, ensuring that:
    a. Your cup is catching the espresso dripping out of both spouts of your portafilter.
    b. For best results, the hot water should run through the puck and into the cup for about 25 to 30 seconds. Notify your supervisor if your shot is pulling faster or slower than this. Your supervisor will then dial in your group head to re-calibrate it.
8. When making drinks, only use a shot of espresso that is fresher than 3 - 5 minutes. Espresso loses flavor when exposed to air, becoming more bitter. Dumping your espresso shot into water or milk slows down this process dramatically. A shot of espresso is still good to use if it still has “crema” on top. If you’re unsure whether a shot of espresso is still good, it’s better to pull a fresh one than to serve a customer an old one. Remember, one of the company’s core values is: *do the right thing*.

Note: When not in use, its best to keep your portafilter screwed into a group head on your espresso machine. This will pre-heat the portafilter, leading to better espresso.

3. Steaming your milk

Properly steamed milk elevates the taste of a latte. It has a smooth, silky texture with little to no bubbles. A steam wand heats and aerates a pitcher of milk. A properly placed steam wand creates a whirlpool effect that steams your milk evenly.

Learning how to steam milk well takes time and practice. Keep at it, and don't be afraid to ask your supervisor for tips on how to improve your technique.

1. Select the appropriate pitcher for the milk you are about to steam. If the pitcher is dirty, rinse it in the pitcher rinser.
    a. There are different pitchers for regular milk versus milk substitutes. The pitchers meant for oat, soy, and almond milk are labeled. Be careful not to mix them up—the wrong type of milk could give the customer an allergic reaction.
2. For a 16 oz double latte, pour milk into the pitcher until it is slightly above the base of its spout.
    a. Note: steaming your milk will increase its volume by 20 to 50 percent.
3. Pull the lever to vent the steam wand before each use. This will get out any old milk, which could block the steam or get into your pitcher.
4. Place the steam wand halfway between the center of the milk pitcher and one of its sides. Place the head of the wand beneath the surface of your milk. Hold the pitcher flat. This position will ensure the steam creates a whirlpool in the milk.
5. Pull the lever on the steam wand to begin steaming the milk. When you start steaming, you will know the steam wand and milk pitcher are properly positioned if the milk whirlpools and you hear a sound like shredding paper. If instead of shredding paper, your steam wand sounds like a jet engine, your milk will end up poorly steamed. You will either need to adjust the angle of your pitcher, the angle of your steam wand, the position of your steam wand, or the depth of the steam wand in the milk.

Whole milk	Skim milk	Oat, soy, or almond milk.
Steams in about 25 – 35 seconds.	Steams quickly, in about 20 – 30 seconds.	Steams quickly, in about 20 – 30 seconds.

6. To ensure that you don't steam the milk too long, turn off the steam wand when you hear the sound of ripping paper deepen. This typically happens a couple of seconds after the milk pitcher becomes uncomfortably hot to the touch. Wait five seconds for the milk in your pitcher to settle, giving time for any bubbles in the milk to rise to the surface.
    a. Steaming your milk too long will burn it. Burnt milk gives off a rubbery smell. A pitcher of burnt milk will also be incredibly hot to the touch.

	Perfectly steamed milk	Under steamed milk	Over steamed milk
Bubbles	Few to no bubbles.	Few to no bubbles.	Many bubbles break up the surface.
How surface looks	Silky, glossy, and shiny. Looks like wet paint.	Looks like regular milk from the fridge.	Foamy.
What sound it typically makes while steaming	Ripping paper	Ripping paper or jet engine	Jet engine
Surface tension	Yes	No	Yes
Makes for good latte art	Yes	No	No

7. Well steamed milk can still have some bubbles on its surface. There are a few techniques to remove these bubbles. However, these tricks cannot fix poorly steamed milk, only improve the final result. Break up bubbles by:

a. Tapping your milk pitcher on the counter.

b. Swirling milk around in the pitcher.

8. Pour your steamed milk into the cup in a circular motion. This motion mixes the espresso into the steamed milk.
9. Clean the milk off your steam wand soon after you finish steaming. If you wait too long, the heat of the steam wand will cause milk to crust, making it harder to clean. Grab the rag on top of the espresso machine. To clean the steam wand, vent out a little air while wiping it up and down with the rag. Whenever venting the steam wand, avoid sticking your hand beneath it or you will get burned.

Note: Some customers want their drink to be cooler or extra hot. Others prefer their milk less foamy (flat white), or extra foamy (dry). These preferences will be specified through the cup code.

Tip: Well-aerated milk is ideal for latte art. Practicing latte art is a good way to improve your ability to steam milk. Practice by pouring hearts or ferns on top of your lattes.

4. Serving Drinks

1. Place your finished drink on the pickup counter within easy reach of customers.
2. Shout out the name and order written on the cup. It is important to shout because Gates and Wean Hall are loud, and customers often walk away instead of waiting for their drinks.
3. If no one picks up the cup after 3 minutes, shout the order again. Do this again after 5 minutes.
4. Throw the cup away if it is not picked up after 10 minutes. A drink that sits too long will taste bad, and eventually become too unsanitary to serve. If the original customer returns, let them know you had to throw it away and offer to remake their drink.

Note: Sometimes customers take a drink meant for another customer. If this happens, remake that drink before starting any new drinks. This aligns with one of La Prima's core values: finishing the job.

What happens when you type “youtube.com” into the web browser?

Every day we look something up on the internet. But what actually happens when we type in a web address like “www.youtube.com” into our browser and hit enter? How does our browser work behind the scenes to magically locate the website, connect to the website, then load that website in our browser? The whole thing happens so quickly these days, we rarely have time to think about it. And when we try to learn how our browser works, we see sentences like, “the url’s domain name is used to query the dns resolver associated with its specified domain ending,” and our brain immediately hits the eject button. The explanations are dense, unapproachable, and give no entry point to the average person.

The good news is that searching the web is a lot more straightforward than software engineers make it out to be. The power of modern computers lies in simplifying complexity. This means that users only need to know how to use the computer, not what the computer is actually doing in the background to make that happen. When you drive a car, you only need to focus on driving. You put your foot on the accelerator and turn the steering wheel. This makes technology easier to adopt (think of how quickly people took up the iPhone). But ironically, this seamless use also makes the inner workings of the internet harder to understand. The actual technical stuff is tucked behind the curtain like the Wizard of Oz.

But not knowing becomes scary when everything is online, when social media is the town square, and corporations and governments can dictate how we shop, work, and socialize online. If we don’t know what’s going on behind the scenes when we use the internet, then we as users are powerless to decide what the internet should look like.

Now is a good time to pop off the “hood” and get your arms a little dirty. No one likes being at the mercy of a shady mechanic. In four steps, we will outline how your web browser has been working this whole time:

In brief, your browser first looks up the website's address. Second, it connects to the website's server. Third, it requests the web page from the website's server. Finally, it displays the web page on your screen.

Here's how that happens, in detail:

Step 1: Looking up the web address.

Before your browser can connect to a website such as "youtube.com," it needs to be able to find it. The browser finds a website's location by asking a DNS server. DNS stands for a Domain Name Server. A DNS server receives a web address (such as "youtube.com"), and returns the website's actual digital address, called an IP address. IP address stands for Internet Protocol. It is a numerical address that is assigned to every device connected to a computer network.

To illustrate this, think of looking up a website's location like looking up someone's name in a phone book. The DNS server is the phone book. The web address is the name of the person you are looking up in the phone book. The IP address is like the phone number you find under their name that lets you get in contact with them.

A DNS server turns a human-friendly web address into a machine-friendly IP address. The address of a website, such as "youtube.com," is known as its URL (Uniform Resource Locator). URLs are user-friendly – they are easy to remember, easy to read, and easy to type. In the background, however, the browser must convert the URL address ("youtube.com") into a numbered address called an IP address (172.217.19.164). An IP address tells your browser exactly where a website is located on the internet. To convert a URL into an IP address, your browser sends the URL to a DNS server. The DNS server then sends back the URL's corresponding IP address.

With that overview in mind, lets go through each step in more detail. When you type the website's URL into the browser and hit enter, your search request travels from your computer, over Wi-Fi or Ethernet, and into your router. The router then passes your search request from your house to your Internet Service Provider (ISP).

To speed up this process, your Internet service provider stores the IP addresses of commonly searched websites. If the website you are looking up has been recently searched, your ISP can quickly look up the web address and send back its corresponding IP address. Now, your browser has the website's IP address, and therefore, knows how to get in touch with it.

However, sometimes the website you are looking up has not been recently searched by anyone. If this is the case, your ISP needs to request this information from a DNS server. Remember, a DNS server turns a human-friendly web address into a machine-friendly IP address. The catch? There a many different DNS servers, with each handling a different list of websites. This is where the root DNS server comes in.

The root DNS server acts like a dispatcher for other DNS servers. To go back to our phone book metaphor, you send the root DNS server the name of the person you want to get in contact with, then the root DNS server tells you which phone book to look them up in.

How does this work in practice? Your ISP messages the root DNS server. The root DNS server reads the URL, then tells your ISP which DNS server contains that website's IP address. The ISP then gets in touch with that specific DNS server. Once your ISP receives the website's IP address, it sends it back to your browser.

Using DNS servers to lookup web URLs provides a couple advantages. For one, DNS servers allow a website to have multiple IP addresses. This speeds up a user's connection to a website. This is because the DNS server can send the user the IP address of the server closest to them. In addition, DNS servers allow websites to more easily perform maintenance on their servers. Servers can be added or removed without the user ever noticing.

Did you know?
There are actually multiple root DNS servers. Thirteen global non-profits collaborate to run these root DNS servers. The biggest and most important of these is ICANN, which is responsible for managing, maintaining, and setting the global standard for DNS servers. Each non-profit operates its own root DNS server. These non-profits then allow private companies such as GoDaddy to sell people the

exclusive right to a specific web addresses. This model helps ensure that the internet remains decentralized while still being able to inter-operate.

The internet as we know it today depends on the hard work of non-profits such as ICANN, IEEE, and IETF. They work tirelessly to maintain code, standards, and infrastructure. Without them, the internet wouldn't work!

Step 2: Establishing a connection to the server.

Using the IP address acquired in step 1, your browser can now locate YouTube's web server. Next, your browser needs to establish a stable connection with this server.

To establish a connection, your browser needs to first initiate contact with the server. Your browser does this by messaging YouTube's web server. Your browser addresses the message to the server's IP address. This message does two things. First, it tells the server that your browser would like to initiate contact. Second, it allows the browser and server to agree ahead of time what to do if a message is lost in transit. Messages get lost all the time, either because a router is broken, the network is congested, or the data gets corrupted in transit. For this reason, the browser and server need to agree ahead of time what to if a message does get lost. Otherwise, communication between the browser and the server can fall apart.

Whenever two computers communicate over the internet, they use different protocols to send and receive data. To establish a connection with the server, your browser uses a protocol called TCP (Transmission Control Protocol).

Think of TCP like the post system. TCP handles the act of communicating. It sends messages, reads messages, and maintains a stable connection. By establishing a TCP connection, your browser can use other communication protocols to focus solely on transmitting data. If TCP is the post system, these other communication protocols are the messages being sent in the mail.

Did you know?
Having one protocol handle communication, while another protocol handles content, is called "separation of concerns." Separation of concerns allows each protocol to split up the complicated work of communicating over the internet. That way, each protocol can focus on doing one thing well. Without separation of concerns, there would be no internet!

Step 3: Retrieving the web page.

Now that a stable connection has been established, your browser can finally retrieve YouTube's web page. If the previous step was about setting up the postal service, this step is about using that service to deliver a message to YouTube's servers. In this case, your browser sends a message requesting the web page from YouTube's server.

A web page is stored as a series of documents (we will go into further detail in step 4). These documents tell the browser what the website's content is (e.g. text, buttons, search bars), as well as how to format this content. In order to retrieve the web page, your browser must make a new type of request to the server called an HTTP request.

HTTP is *the* communication protocol for communicating with websites and other web services. HTTP communications are sent over the TCP connection established in step 2. This separation of concerns means that HTTP can focus on providing web content, while the underlying TCP connection can focus on maintaining a strong connection.

Once received, YouTube's server will attempt to respond to your HTTP request by gathering all the documents necessary to display YouTube's home page. YouTube's server will then attempt to send back the requested web page as a series of files, as well as a status code indicating whether it was successful.

Sometimes the server succeeds in responding to your request, other times it fails. The server can fail for a variety of reasons, such as faulty code or missing files. If this happens, the server will instead send back an error status code with no web page. You might be familiar with the most common error message: "404 – not found." When your web browser displays a 404 message, that means your browser was able to communicate with the server, but the server was unable to find the web page you requested.

Step 4: Displaying the web page.

Using the files received in step 3, your browser can finally display YouTube's homepage. The browser does this by translating these files into a graphic display. Typically, a web page is made up of three main types of files: HTML, CSS, and JavaScript. All of these documents play a different role in building the web page.

You might already be familiar with HTML (Hypertext Markup Language). HTML describes a website's content, as well as how that content is structured. Think of it like the blueprint of a house. HTML contains elements such as the text, headings, tables, and search bar.

CSS is the style guide that tells the browser how to style the website's content. Think of it like the decorations in a house. CSS contains the colors, margins, and font size for the website.

Finally, JavaScript is a programming language that makes the website more interactive. Think of it like the plumbing and electricity in a house – without it, the sink or appliances wouldn't work! JavaScript handles automation, animations, and user interaction.

JavaScript runs locally on your device. Without JavaScript, your browser would first need to message the server before updating your web page. You wouldn't be able to seamlessly hover over a drop-down menu or select different t-shirt colors in an online store without having to reload the entire web page.

In conclusion:

Hopefully, this helps you appreciate how incredible and complicated the internet is. By forgoing unnecessary technical details, this explanation helps you understand what exactly happens when you look up a website.

To recap, whenever you type "youtube.com" into your browser and hit enter, your browser 1. looks up the website's address using a DNS server, 2. connects to the website using TCP, 3. retrieves the web page from the server in the form of files, and 4. displays the web page on your screen.

It is amazing that all of this happens in a matter of seconds, especially when considering that this process can span across countries. The internet is a culmination of centuries of research in math, engineering, and material science. What's more, the amount of collaboration required to make it work is staggering.

Understanding how the internet works is empowering. You are engaging with a deeply complex system, but a system that is capable of being understood. Ironically, knowing how it works imbues the whole thing with a true sense of wonder.

UX Writing Project - Export Course Button for Canvas

Augustus Saalfeld

Executive Summary

This document includes the research and writing necessary to announce a new feature for the online learning platform Canvas. Professors use Canvas to administer their course, allowing them to structure their course, share readings, facilitate discussions, grade assignments, and send announcements. For most university students, Canvas is the primary if not the only way to access the modules, readings, and discussion posts that make up their course.

My research led me to propose a new feature for Canvas that allows students to export a course out of Canvas and onto their local computer or cloud storage in as few clicks as possible. This new feature addresses a pain-point shared by interviewees: they cannot review course content when they cannot access the internet or their Canvas accounts. Once exported, students without wifi can still access their readings, lectures, or discussion posts while they are travelling home for the holidays. Alumni can use this feature to review their course content long after graduating, without relying on their university to maintain their access to Canvas.

This document contains three sections: research summary, feature announcement, and microcopy that you would find in the feature. Each section also contains a design summary which grounds my content decisions in user research.

Research

Feature Design Process

[Link to Miro Board]

I iterated towards a solution using the five steps of design thinking: emphasize, define, ideate, prototype, and test. First, I created two personas and an empathy map based on my own experience and an interview with an alumni. Second, I synthesized these interviews into 5 pain points, which I then rephrased as “how might we” statements in order define the problem in a way that centers the user. Third, I brainstormed several solutions and prototyped a UX mockup for one of these solutions using Obsidian. Finally, I tested my prototype on classmates and collected their feedback with a survey.

Feature Design Summary:

The design process informed the feature and how I chose to break it down into smaller pieces of microcopy. The feature needs to be quick to use and allow students to easily access their course content. Currently, it would take too long to manually download each reading and module from a course on Canvas. An export course button leading to a form could export your entire course in a few as five clicks.

Canvas already has a lot of features cluttering its user interface. Without clear UX writing, the new feature will go undiscovered in the clutter. The placement, content, and word choice of the microcopy that makes up the new feature must therefore distinguish and explain the new feature. Users must also be pointed to the new feature with a properly motivating feature announcement.

Feature Announcement

Feature Announcement Summary

Purpose: *To inform users and alumni about Canvas' new "export course" feature, allowing users to export their course content out of Canvas and onto their local computer or cloud storage. To motivate users and alumni to use this feature.*
Audience: *Current university students and alumni.*
Design summary:

I tried to copy the four genre moves of a feature announcement: (1) introduce the new feature, (2) explain its key benefits, (3) show how it works, and (4) encourage users to try it immediately).

- When introducing the new feature, I studied the language of other feature announcements (Spotify, Ticketmaster, GoodReads). In the first couple of sentences of their feature announcements, the writers used the following pattern to rapidly summarize the new feature: The product owner V's goal is W, which is why we added X feature so that Y people can do Z activity. I copied this pattern for the first two sentences of my feature announcement.
- When explaining its benefits, I described both the feature's value (fast, more accessible courses), as well as some real-life use cases for users (student accessing courses offline, alumni accessing courses after graduating).
- When showing how the feature works, I described where to find UI elements in order to help situate readers. I also structured the explainer as a sequential list of steps.
- To encourage users to try it immediately, I ended by conveying the value of the tool as well as providing an example of a type of person who could benefit (hoping that the person reading is that type of person).
    - I addressed the reader as "you" in the final paragraph to prompt them to take action.

- In the feature announcement, I motivated users to try the new feature by saying that it gives them permanent ownership over their course content. The idea to motivate users with ownership came out of ideating and prototyping. While designing the feature, I discovered that if students could export their courses out of Canvas, they would then have ownership over the course files, and could store or access them whenever or however they wanted. From my interviews, students said that owning their course content would make it easier for them to access.

Feature Announcement

Canvas wants to give you the power to learn wherever and whenever you want, which is why we are introducing the course export feature. Students can use the course export feature to download their courses off Canvas and onto their local device or cloud storage account. The export feature allows you to quickly download all the readings, modules, discussions, and feedback in any course - past or present. Busy college students can export their courses and then access them offline, so they catch up on coursework while travelling home for the holidays.

You can export a course in as little as five clicks. The button for exporting a course can be found in the top-right of the "all courses" page, as well as in the top-right of any course's homepage. Once pressed, an export window will appear. Select the course content you would like to download, such as files, modules, or discussion posts. Then select the export destination. You can decide to download the course to your local device, or you can log into your cloud storage account and export it there. Finally, select whether you would like to compress the export into a zip file, reducing the file size at the cost of making it more difficult to open.

Once you are happy with your choices, hit the download button. The export window will show a progress bar for the download as well as a success or failure message once the download is complete. If the download fails, you can usually resolve the issue by referring to this table of error messages.

Canvas is committed to guaranteeing students long-term access to their educational content. Exporting your course content gives you ownership over it. Once exported, you can access it on whatever device you want without the need for a Canvas account.

Graduating soon? Travelling without wifi? Simply log onto Canvas, select a course, and use the export course button today to secure access to your course content far into the future.

Microcopy

Microcopy Summary

Purpose: *Microcopy are small components of written text and sometimes symbols that make up a user interface. This microcopy implements the new export course feature. Microcopy must explain what a feature does, how to use the feature, and provide feedback to user inputs. Microcopy must be clear, concise, and consistent with the feature.*
Audience: *Current university students and alumni.*
Design summary:
I chose to write microcopy that includes challenges commonly faced by UX professional writers:

- I wrote several pieces of microcopy for the export form. In doing so, I had to make sure that each piece of microcopy was cohesive with the entire form. For example, the success and error messages must reference the export destination selected by the user.
- To avoid lawsuits, a tool like this needs a legal summary explaining that it may be illegal for students to distribute course content without permission. The legal summary has to succinctly warn the reader, while trying not to come across as rude or overly restrictive.
- I wrote a two-sentence summary that appears when users hover over the export course button. If the feature is not well introduced, then it will get lost in the clutter of Canvas' UI.

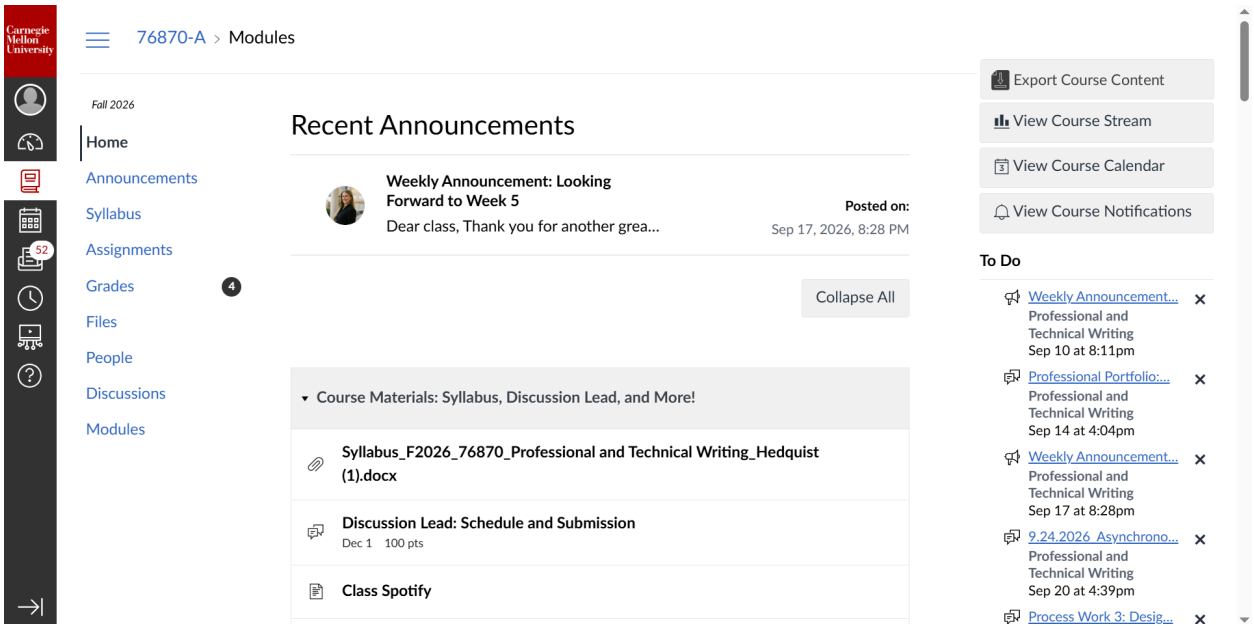
Microcopy Content

Microcopy as text

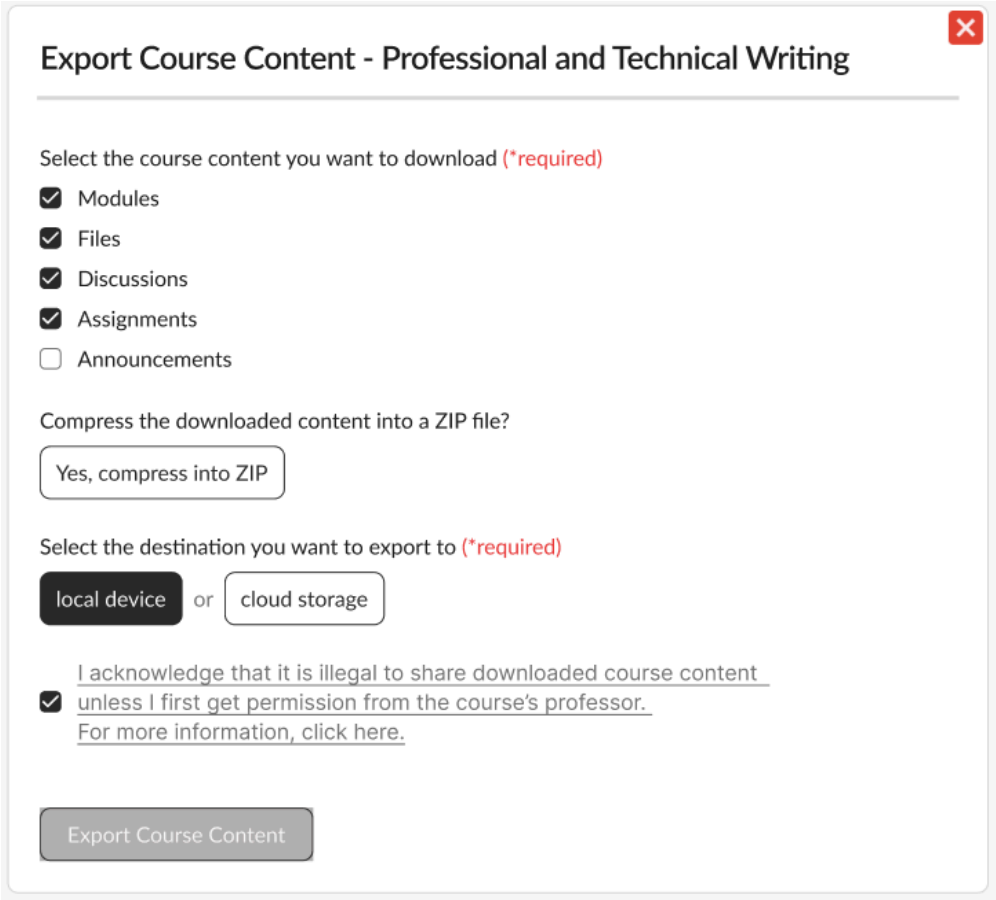
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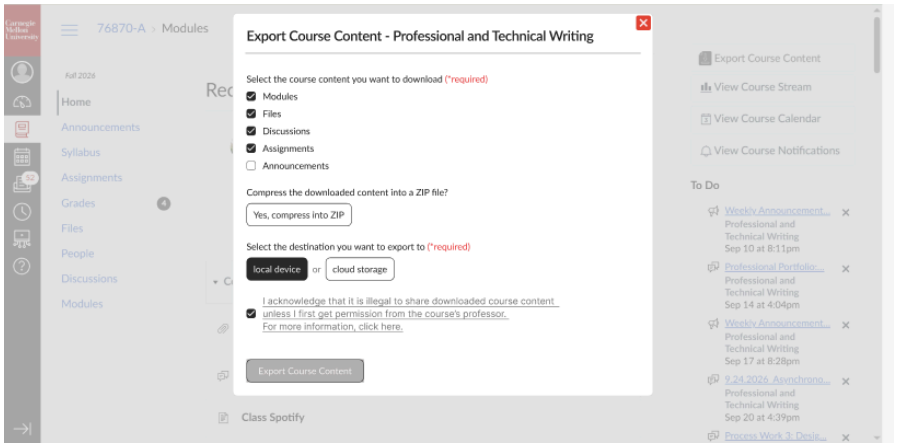
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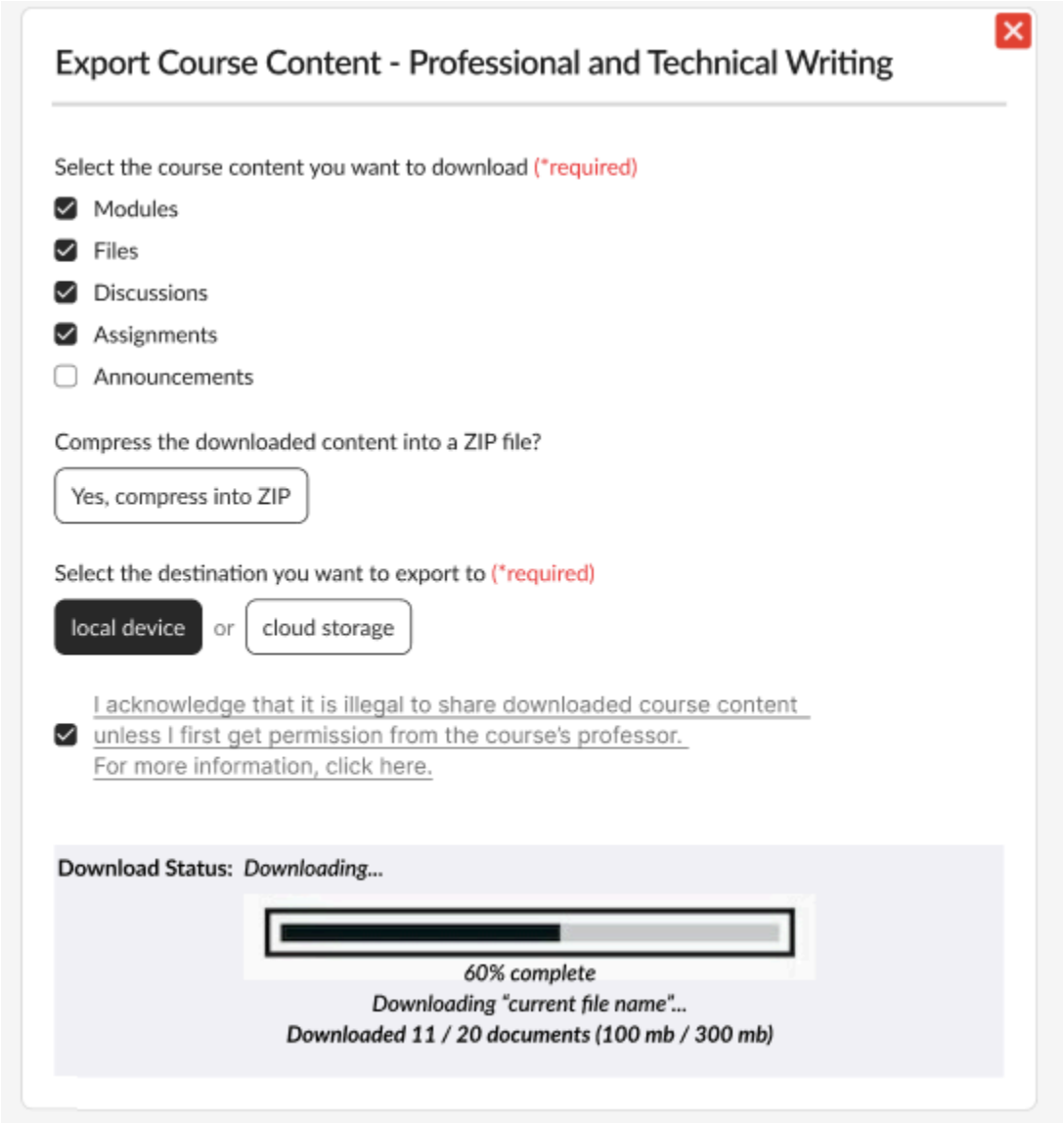


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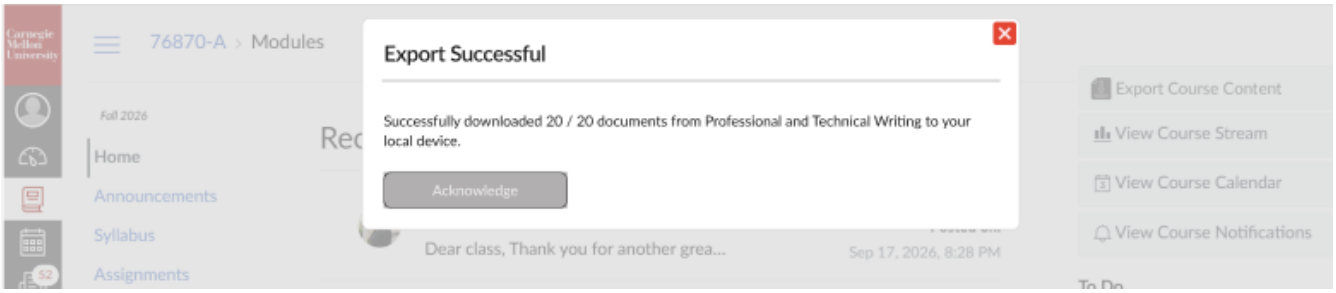




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Why growing mushrooms at home can improve your kitchen skills and save you money

For two billion years, an organism has been growing under my feet—and I just noticed it. For most of my life, I didn't think much of mushrooms. It wasn't until, on a Friday night not too long ago, I was stuck at home after a long week of being broke and busy, that I began scheming of a project which could improve my time around the house. I needed something that was 1. cheap (broke) and 2. easy to fit into my schedule (busy). I already had an herb garden, but planting an actual garden seemed like too much work. That was when I stumbled across mushroom growing. In three simple steps, I watched as mushroom growers turned a few mushroom cells into an entire mushroom farm.

With just 3 or 4 hours of work across 6 weeks, I was harvesting my first blue oyster mushrooms. I've since gone on to expand my collection, growing lion's mane (which tastes like crab) and pink oyster mushrooms (which taste like bacon). Harvesting a couple pounds of mushrooms each week cuts down the cost of my meals. With the price of meat so high, it's nice to have a substitute on hand which is cheap, healthy, and delicious. And they don't taste like grocery store mushrooms. You will get to experiment with the many, *many* delicious recipes you can make with them. My first harvest was a great opportunity to invite friends over for a gourmet dinner party, with a menu of fried oyster mushrooms and mushroom birria tacos.

This short guide will teach you how to grow your own blue oyster mushrooms at home. I've chosen blue oyster mushrooms because they are beginner friendly. Blue oysters grow in under a month, produce high yields, and are particularly resistant to other bacteria and fungus. Growing blue oyster mushrooms is easy, once you've familiarized yourself with the following steps and acquired the necessary equipment.

The three steps to growing your own mushrooms at home

First, growers inject a syringe filled with mycelium into a bag of grain. This is called "inoculating grain spawn." After 2 to 4 weeks, the mycelium will expand and fully envelop all of the grain in the bag. In the second step, called "spawn to bulk," this grain is layered in a bucket with straw. In the third step, the mixture is misted for 2 to 4 weeks, during which little "pins" will start to sprout out of the mycelium. These pins will grow into a fully-formed mushroom over the course of a week, doubling in size every day until they are ready to harvest with a quick pull.

Equipment

- 10cc liquid culture syringe of blue oyster mushrooms. You can buy one from a small farm or a mushroom growing supplier.
- 1lb bag of grain with an injection port and a 0.2 Micron Filter. You can buy one from a small farm or a mushroom growing supplier.
- 2 lbs of straw to be used as the "soil" to grow the mushrooms. (Insider tip: this straw is what mushroom growers would call our "substrate"). You can buy one ?.
- 16oz bottle of 70% isopropyl alcohol. Don't substitute with liquor.
- A soup pot that is larger than 5 qts.
- a spray bottle, the finer the misting nozzle the better.
- A still air box.
- A grow bucket.

And now to the actual mushrooms!

1. Inoculating Your Grain With Blue Oyster Mycelium

Preparing your work area:

Before inoculating the grain spawn, gather your materials and clean off your work area. Put your grain bag and liquid culture syringe in your still air box. Soak a paper towel in alcohol and use it to wipe down the insides of the still air box.

Keep in mind that bacteria and mold on our own bodies can also contaminate our work. Take a shower and wear freshly laundered clothes. Gloves and a face-mask are optional but lower your risk of accidentally introducing unwanted bacteria into your grain bag. Try to minimize the air currents in the room as much as possible. Turn off any fans as well as your central air unit. This will help keep the air-flow in the still air box to a minimum.

Inoculating your grain spawn:

When working in a still air box, it is important to move at a deliberate pace—neither too fast or too slow. When you are ready, rub your hands thoroughly in alcohol. Soak a paper towel in some alcohol, then reach into the box and wipe the surface of the grain bag's "self-healing" injection port.

Uncap your syringe and inject it through the injection port. Spray your syringe evenly throughout the grain bag by gently wiggling it as you spray. Then, gently remove the needle from the grain bag and wipe down the injection site once more with your alcohol soaked paper towel.

Congratulations, you have successfully inoculated your first grain bag!

Storing your grain bag and waiting for it to fully colonize

Your grain bag will provide a sterile environment for the oyster mushrooms to grow in. Store your grain bag in a closet, a garage, or a basement. Just make sure the room maintains a stable temperature between 60 to 75 degrees.

Mycelium is made of thousands of white strands that look like stringy or fluffy growth. Slowly, these growths will envelope the grains in the bag. This can take three to five weeks. When the bag is

about 20% colonized, break the mycelium block apart and spread the colonized grain evenly throughout the bag. This will speed up growth.

Once a week, look into the bag to check for contaminants. There are many contaminants to look out for, which you can learn more about by reading here.

You will know that your grain spawn is ready for the next step when the mycelium has completely taken over your grain bag. At this point, very little grain will be visible in the bag.

2. Spawn-to-bulk and preparing your grow bucket

Once your grain bag is fully colonized, you will be ready to mix it with your straw in your grow bucket and begin fruiting your oyster mushrooms. Mushroom growers call this step "*spawn-to-bulk*." They layer colonized grains and straw to help the mycelium spawn oyster mushrooms. The grains allow the blue oysters to rapidly colonize the straw, while the straw retains water to nourish the mushrooms.

First, prepare the straw. In a large pot, boil enough water to submerge 2 pounds of straw. Boil the straw for an hour. This will ensure that your straw is hydrated and pasteurized. Dump out the water, leaving the straw. In order to test that your straw is sufficiently hydrated, grab a clump and give it a good squeeze. Your mixture is properly hydrated if rivulets of water run out for roughly 2 to 4 seconds(?).

Next, fill the bottom of your grow bucket with a layer of straw about one inch thick. Layer some grain spawn over top the straw. Repeat this process until you have filled up your bucket, then place your lid on top. Place your bucket anywhere with decent air flow, as long as it is out of direct sunlight —options include your garage or under a tree. If an upcoming heatwave or cold-snap is forecasted, bring your bucket inside until it passes.

3. Fruiting & Harvesting:

Here's a quick overview of your timeline from now until harvest: it usually takes 10 to 21 days for the mycelium in the grain to expand out into the straw. It then takes another five days for "pins" to begin sprouting from the holes of the bucket. "Pins" are the precursor to mushrooms. Once formed, they will take another week to grow into blue oyster mushrooms.

Spray the holes in the grow bucket generously twice a day. Check on their progress by peering through the grow holes or taking off the lid.

Harvesting is easy. You will know your blue oyster mushrooms are ready to harvest once the edge of their caps begin to curl upwards. Simply grab a bushel of oyster mushrooms from the base of their stem, twist it, and pull it free of the grow bucket. Enjoy!

Now that you know the basics, here's what to learn next:
There are still many more things to discover about growing mushrooms, for example:

- Harvest another round of blue oyster mushrooms from your grow bucket by soaking it in water.
- Cut down on costs significantly by making your own grain bags or liquid culture syringes.
- Research "grain-to-grain" transfers and learn how mushroom growers turn one fully colonized grain bag into ten.

For some far out there ideas, consider turning mycelium into art, clothing, and furniture; using mushrooms to boost your vegetable garden; and using mycoremediation to remove pollutants from your local ecosystem.

Views From East 1st to Marble Hill

Before Dawn – 6:00am

A young man stands in front of the mirror of his unheated bathroom. Sleepy eyed, he stares through the glass, toothbrush hovering. For a while he is unable to recognize his own face, only the outline of his body can he identify. He brushes his teeth but forgets the toothpaste.

Dawn – 7:00am

A family shares breakfast at the same table, but eats in separate rooms.

Morning – 8:45am

An old man sits perfectly still on the subway. He has on a black hat, a loosely fitted jacket overtop a smartly striped button-down which he has tucked into his pants, and squeezed between his knees a heavy leather-bound briefcase – all items the kind of which are not made like they used to. The subway car jostles him, tries to startle him with unpredictable sounds of metal-on-metal, casts shadows upon his face. It goads the children to snicker at him, and, were he to ever to turn around, would make them avert their gaze so far away as to only be directed at him. The old man, for his part, simply coughs once and looks on. What does he see, looking so intently ahead? Perhaps he imagines he is in the belly of a great worm, thin translucent panes beaten into its skin, outside of which contains the secrets of a foreign land.

Morning – 9:30am

A little girl, walking to school, one hand in her father's and the other on a street-vended hotdog, drops the bun down a sidewalk grate to see where it goes.

Morning – 11:00am

A construction worker lies backwards on a support beam, lifts his shirt, and drinks in the perfect blue sky with his exposed belly. He dreams that he is flying, accompanying the single cloud above. His body spreadeagle, he soars higher with every flap of his arms. The hammers and clangs of construction are the birdsong of gulls and the sound of distant thunder.

Morning – 11:30am

Employees at the water cooler, who cool themselves with gossip like gazelles at a watering hole, scatter when they see their boss approaching.

Noon – 11:50am to 12:30pm

Today is the parade! The parade for what (or more appropriately, for 'whom,' if you are in the know) you ask? Why, it is the parade for Thomas, of course! All around the city, street sweeps and housing committees have been putting up streamers since before dawn. The road has been cleared from his home on 34th all the way down to Madison Avenue to make way for the floats. Some kids are let out of school early. The precinct has tasked only their finest and most affable cops to oversee the processions, and they laugh and smile and pin plastic badges upon the chests

of children. Hawkers unfurl their blankets and place upon them all sorts of commemorative knick-knacks. One such hawker is engaged in heated argument with a group of Japanese tourists after attempting to set up shop beneath their feet; they, who had flown in this morning with the express purpose of coalescing underneath this convenience store, brandishing their digital cameras and extendable photo-sticks, ready to eternalize the occasion. And look, here he comes! The parade float is capacious – it has room for every color fit for a party. A flurry of cheers escorts the float, passing down the busy streets like a relay baton. Thomas stands, head bowed in gratitude, but unbent by misplaced flattery. He is wearing a sweater the color of golden October, a choice which the announcers agree really brings out his eyes. Crowds press against the barricades trying to get closer.

Suddenly, the assembled mass discovers a weak-spot, and the cops are helpless as throngs of fans surround the float. They grab its flowing tassels; a sea of bodies, they reach out with loving arms towards the object of their affection. Several people try to climb atop the float but are quickly pushed off by the security detail back onto the mass below. Thomas smiles bashfully at the crowd, bends down on one knee and touches his followers on their hands and foreheads. Limbs, the pressure of body-on-body, ecstatic shouts which punctuate the percussion of the marching band. In one corner of the festivity, unseen to all, a woman is crushed underneath the wheel of the parade float, only to be discovered much later.

Noon – 12:50

A man sits at a baseball game and is hungry. He feels a thousand eyes from rows and rows boring into the back of his head.

Lunch Rush – 1:00pm

The offices are let out for 30 minutes of lunch. The boss turns a kitchen timer.

Midday – 1:10pm

Having waited long enough, the customers at the local deli are now furious. Packed in like sardines, they repurpose kitchen-ware and three-legged stools and descend vengefully upon the woefully outnumbered employees manning the counter, determined to make their own lunch.

Midday – 1:15pm

Among the bustle of 34 and 3rd, a woman closes her eyes and sees for the first time an empty street.

Midday – 1:25pm

A man collapses in the middle of a crowd. Pressing in, they all try CPR.

Midday – 1:30pm

The kitchen timer goes off.

Midday – 1:30pm

The hotdog is still falling.

Afternoon – 2:00pm

Having improperly brushed his teeth this morning, the office-worker took lunch at his desk, where he subsequently fell asleep. Bleary-brained, he lifts his head up from his cubicle into the grid of unearthly fluorescent lamps, and finds above him the brilliance of heaven. He files paperwork underneath the firmament. Out the window, and across the street, in a tower larger than all the rest, throughout every floor of its stratified architecture, and in every room within each floor, lies the Great Chain of Being.

Afternoon – 3:32pm

A student stares lazily out the window of fourth period math, and guesses, with perfect accuracy, what the world will look like in 15 years.

Afternoon – 4:15pm

Two conspiratorial siblings gnaw at the rope their parents have tied to them while they go grocery shopping.

Afternoon – 4:16pm

Cleanup in aisle 6.

Afternoon – 4:17pm

May the Vandenberger parents please come to the checkout in lane 3. We have your children, and will ransom them back once you have paid us their worth in damaged groceries.

Afternoon – 5:30pm

In the afternoons, the smell of grilled meats over charcoal perfumes the parks where old men play chess, and extended families come to lay blankets in the shade. It is times like these when your brain can feel like sunshine.

Evening – 6:30pm

As they step off the train, exhausted from a long day's work, people slough off the spindly arms of their chrysalis skins and greet their smiling children. As they come off, the skins make a snapping noise; the empty husks lie dormant on the platform like dead praying mantises, where they will be swept up by staff later in the night.

Evening – 7:45pm

A tankard of wine punctures. A bar floods. The merry drunks grab on to tables, chairs, each other, as they are taken away by their bacchanalian pleasures. En route, they continue to toast to their health.

Gloaming – 9:00pm

In the soft glow of twilight, a man, stabbed, falls into the arms of his assailant. Like lovers, he sinks syrupy into their burly frame, and watches as the alley lamps and window lights turn themselves on one by one, like the first night of fireflies in autumn.

Shower Thought

Buddhist cosmology, as described in the Sutta Pitaka of the Theravada Pali Canon, stratifies thirty-one different planes of existence in which rebirth takes place; Hinduism assigns fourteen, seven upper and seven lower planes. Perhaps more attuned to modern sensibilities, of which includes the expectation of infinity, the modern spiritualist ascertains that our reality exists as one among many equally valid existences. A simple exercise to access these realities is as follows:

Sit beneath the shower head, any brand will do, and turn the knobs until the water is comfortable, vaguely steamy—though not too hot!—and all-consuming. A sauna may also work.

Massage your scalp in deep, lazy ovals. Let the water slip between your fingers, and land like the gentlest hail. Interpret the world through touch, in which there is only volume, pattern, pressure. Appreciate that touch has its own kind of warmth which can be felt through anything. Trace each shiver of joy. Pleasure pools at the base of your spine, running up and down, going a little further each time. Reaching your shoulder blades, the nape of your neck, below your jaw.

Tilt your head back and forth without interruption, smoothly. As you do, notice how the water and the feelings of your hands move on a shared point; overlapping like glass, joining faintness to fullness; creating, not a feeling, but a spectrum, so that the space above your head grows to contain all things. You may be surprised at how light it all is, this point of everything. It rests on your head like a feather, tickling you hilarious with possibility.

The pleasure has now reached your head. You go numb so that you don't know where *you* ends. Your brain, brimming with energy, leaps through where you once felt your skull, and for a blinding instant, joins in the point of infinity above.

For a time, you will exist in white-hot everything. Seeing all things at once is unsurprisingly similar to seeing nothing at all. With no point of reference, there is nothing to distinguish one thing from another. This experience is temporary, and safe, as proved by Orejón's theorem.

Before this technique was attempted, popular opinion among the coffeehouses of Prague and Vienna was that by entering a point of everything, the mind would surely scatter or be driven insane. Orejón's theorem, a theorem interestingly named not after a person, but a tribe from the elevated floodplains of northern Peru, was transcribed by a renounced Franciscan missionary and mathematician into the now pertinent deduction: a point containing everything must, by necessity, include a perfect copy of you. It follows then that the experience must be safe, or the other you, subject to the same laws, would surely perish. It also follows that a point that contains everything—yourself included—cannot contain any more, and so as quickly as you crashed into it, you bounce back out.

Returning to your senses, the first thing you will notice is that you are standing in the shadow of a wall many times your height. Its bricks are the orange of a heated kiln, there are no cracks between them. There is a wall like this on the edge of each province. Beyond it, from a place you cannot see, you can hear a note shared by crickets and birdsong.

You must enter through the gate. At the gate sits a guard who will ask you your name. Give it to him. Yawning, he will unroll a sprawling, stapled scroll which has written on it the name of every man or woman who is still remembered somewhere. The chairs are there for you to sit; finding your name will take some time, though will be surprisingly quick all things considered. There is little to rest your eyes on as you wait besides the lowcut grass and the road behind you. Behind where the serious-faced guard peers through his reading glasses, rushed

attendants hurry to and from the guard house, frantically adding new names or sheafs to the ever-expanding list and cutting out with scissors and carrying away the names of the departed. After some time the guard will clear his throat, address you with a "right this way mister (or missus)," and gesture with a hand to the great polished gates which swing inwards to greet you.

You have been granted entry into one of the many territories of the Border Princes. Passing through the gates reveals the rolling hills of a pastoral dream. A carriage awaits, its steps are steep but the driver extends a broad arm, hoisting you inside so that the chassis rocks a little before coming to rest. With the snap of the reins, you are taken through the winding meadows and small rustic villages. The grass is indistinguishable from flattened jade. The growers of lilac, larkspur, and daffodils are treated as essential as the farmers and shepherds, and the scent of flowers is like a second breeze. In each village, there is a beautiful blacksmith's daughter, and a quiet courageous stable hand that brings flowers for her hair; an old vicar; a mean widow whose door the children dare each other to knock on then run away laughing; many children to do so, and others who bake her lemon bread and cakes, smiling apologetically; a friendly dog; a cheerful town drunk.

The roads are long, designed not for directness but for their aesthetic value; they traverse the land with the thoroughness with which you might memorize the creases in your palm (pruney but now, I'm sure). The cart sashays and bounces, fluttering your eyes and unworking deep, hidden knots from your back. As you approach the palace you realize that all this pales in comparison. Once, in a chance encounter at a train station, a fellow traveler described it to me as what we imagine our minds see when we know we are asleep.

This time, no gates. From the trellises, banners like feisty blue jays. A procession of greeters waits along the sweeping stone promenade, ready to receive you like valets. Yours is not

the only carriage that is arriving, and a greeter will break off from the rest and ask you how you enjoyed their fair countryside; and, to your response, will smile and laugh and compliment you, shouting, “How true! How true!”

Clasping your back with a gloved hand, they will guide you through the entranceway, to hall, to room after room after room. Large chandeliers cast the rooms in fuzzy golds and passionate reds. Your feet will sink ankle-deep into the lolling crimson of the carpet, and with an “oh dear” your guide will show you to the dressing rooms of the court where all wonders of fabrics and resplendent, drooping silks rest on silver hangers. From beneath a cubby, he will withdraw a pair of cedarwood snowshoes. Presenting them like a bottle of champagne, he will explain how they have just been sweeping the court for their convenience in travel and a certain *je ne sais quoi*. He will take you through the great raised chambers with arched ceilings and generous windows which make the whole room feel as if it is floating off the ground. Looking outside, you wonder how you’d previously been so overwhelmed by the relative tameness of the countryside.

And all the while, he will tell you of the prince who rules this land: his favorite pastimes, tastes, significant life moments, recent happenings (a lover he spurned, or perhaps three successive bullseyes in a game of darts), etc. – fawning over him until they look about ready to trip over.

No one here works in servitude, your guide explains. Each and every position is taken up willingly, assigned by the prince based on favor and merit. No law compels them to keep their post, he says, for the princedom of the Border Prince is a sovereignty built upon self-governance. Like this the province operates—down from the lowly street sweep, up to advisors of art and commerce. The servant, for his part, will explain how truly blessed he is to be a servant. When

the court is in session, only they are allowed to sit at the foot of the throne, closest to the prince. If they are like the other servants, they will have attended to their prince for years, waiting on a change in favor, whispering his name as they drift off to sleep.

In reality, there are no natives in the land except the princes themselves, for all the courtiers are visitors like you, who have elected to stay. For all their lavish praises, they are transients loyal only to the prince with the most favorable arrangement. This fact is not hidden, but social custom: a dissatisfied courtier who believes in more will leave the court unimpeded and wander on to the next prince who will welcome him with open arms. Bidding you farewell in the gold-leaf antechamber of the Hall of Great Festivities, your guide will leave you with these final words. Only the prince is the true servant within his lands, and for that we make him ruler of our hearts.

Oh what a rush! The ball at the heart of the palace can go on for days; and revelers tired of dancing or feasting repose in velvet chaise lounges, or retire upstairs to more private suites. Incense, rose-petals, and perfume intoxicate the air. As many as twelve bands occupy the room, competing for your attention. Rather than pressing up close to your favorite, try standing at different distances apart from each, discovering at which point the music combines and takes on new meaning.

Within this hall there exists pleasure in all of its forms. Perhaps, you are drawn towards the woman in the giraffe coat, who invites you to dance with her upon one of the tables. Or perhaps you will find yourself among the starched collars and cable knit sweaters of stern-faced men and women, speaking loudly of politics and the world of forms. If, caught among the ducking and weaving of the quick footed players engaged in one of their many simultaneous party games, you wish to join them, you may do so too. Often, these games overlap so that new

rules must be made. (There is a game within the gardens, that I myself am very fond of, in which croquet players leapfrog over each other.) Sometimes, great golden mirrors are arranged on every wall so that the revelers' mirth extends into infinity.

In the center of the hall, high up on the dais, sits the throne of the prince. When it is occupied, it is surrounded by swooning courtiers; when it is empty—for the prince enjoys the breadth of his domain—rosy-cheeked drunks sit kissing on each other's laps.

Today, perhaps, you are lucky. One of the messengers had reached the prince from deep within the checkerboard gardens, and so he beckons you from his place on the throne. As you approach, he stands up to greet you. He is tall and broad-shouldered, his hair greying like precious stones. Or, he is slim and lithe, with teeth as sly as a fox. He hunches his shoulders a little when he talks, as if in spite of himself.

"We rarely get visitors from so far away," he says, extending his arm (I do not know whether this is true). His handshake feels simultaneously gentle yet firm. He will suggest that you step off the dais and sit among one of the many small tables, but the choice is yours.

The table is small and round, the kind that one finds outside a café. He will take a genuine interest in your affairs; will laugh only at a good joke, and otherwise rib you toothlessly until you find in that its own humor; surprise you with noble comments and thoughtful insights. You notice that he does not look away when he speaks, but that his eyes are never piercing.

The princes are generally great judges of character, and should he find you to be curious and sincere—the prince despises sycophants, although heartfelt flattery will open many doors—he will move towards deeper conversation. "But come now," he will say, "you must have many

questions." This is an opportunity to ask whatever you like, for the prince will answer all. Avoid, if you can, discussing the other princes.

If you ask him why people take up positions within his princedom, the prince will bend forwards with a knowing smile. A prince must court the innermost desires of his subjects if he is to maintain his position, he explains. He has already given his courtiers everything. Therefore, he must bargain with promises of self-actualization. He adopts the position of the other, what is outside the self, what could be.

And if you fail, you might ask then. His look is frank. The wars between the princes are a social game, the courtiers are pieces, and the moves are luxury and expectation. Diplomacy is at best intrigue, as the princes often backstab and betray, conspire, and conspire to conspire. Pressing his hands together, he explains that princes who fail to do so are vulnerable to the encroaching of an opportunistic rival, and are ultimately subsumed.

If you admit, finally, that you find it difficult to reconcile his seeming frankness, intelligence, even tenderness, with the boundless abandon that orbits his person, the prince will laugh. You might go on to say how, in your culture, temperance in all of its forms is a virtue. He will explain then, finally, how the prince and his many aspirants believe that in order to attain true self-actualization, one must pursue bliss in its many forms, be able to indulge in deepest desire without losing the self. Directing your attention to the hall, he tells you that strife and joy are tightly coupled. The festivities teach the courtiers to overcome their automatic responses to stimuli and assert their right to self-governance. To attain enlightenment, one must be able to contain within themselves all things.

Getting up, he encourages you to ring a silver bell near the back of the hall, which has etched on it the word *feast*. The wooden handle is cool in your palm, and as you ring it, the bell lets out a purifying chime. Almost immediately, a procession of buffet carts pushed by many men supply each table with unique, individualized meals, which they set down next to special name placards. Yours has your name on it, spelt perfectly, and embossed in recycled driftwood. A waiter serves you from your left, placing the plate before your chin so that the steam buffets the front of your face. Rare fruits and cheeses are arranged tastefully around your plate. In its center, a pig leg glistens in its own juices. When you, mouth-watering, skewer the first mouthful and lift it to your face: the lesson is revealed.

Each bite, is, on its own, unpalatable, and attendants regularly place buckets next to the diners to encourage them to vomit. However, once finished, the conquest of the meal imparts a feeling of divine completeness. As you wipe your mouth, the prince smiles. “Deeper than hearing the truth,” he remarks, “you have now tasted it.” In this way, the Border Princes teach their people the satisfaction that exists obscured by effort.

And with this, the prince shall turn to you, and ask the question he asks us all. “And you?” Each word, syllable, breath, is measured. “Will you choose to stay?” To this, only you can answer. But be mindful of this: you can come back, decide to stay, or leave, but you will never make the same choice as this.

There is one last thing to discuss—as you return, slowly, but inevitably, to the shower—that I would be remiss to leave out. A truly bizarre sight. There is a tradition among the courtiers, possibly older than the princes (I know not how) who for their part disapprove, although like all things, do not forbid it. It is a tradition with which I am intimately familiar.

A courtier who has had their heart set on it—which now, I rather reluctantly, will admit to having been—and cannot be deterred, is taken to the only room in the palace without decorations. At the time I had recently lost my wife, and soon after had thrown myself into the exercises. Briefly I was a courtier, but that was not enough. It was a long time ago.

I waited, shivering in the dark, with four other aspirants: a servant, a musician, a minister of culture, and a jester. Only the jester had not chosen to be there, having chosen this to escape execution. The servants affixed a belt around my waist. The belt was flat and leather, except a circular candleholder which protruded below the bellybutton, and a small pouch to the right which stored a tin oiling can. The prince was there to oversee us all. He placed the candlesticks on each holder himself, and then promised that if we could keep the wick alight for the length of the candle, that he would grant us one wish—anything we desired. My prince was stout and puckish. He looked sad. I did not need to say to him what I wished. There was not a day I did not miss my wife, then.

Solemnly, he told us the rules: The candle must burn for at least ten long years—extinguish too soon, and the aspirant will have failed. The candle flame must burn continuously and without interruption, it cannot go out. The belt is magic and cannot come off until the candle has completely burnt through.

We left the room with a feeling of giddy camaraderie, chatting amongst ourselves. We were allowed to return to our normal lives of revelry, but we quickly discovered that the flame was temperamental and required constant attention. Slowly, I learned the best way to cup my hands around the flame, shielding it from errant breezes.

Within the month, the musician's flame was the first to go. Unwilling to do without his instrument, he had continued to play in the Great Hall, where some carefree drunk had knocked him over, extinguishing his light. After that, we stopped attending the riotous parties. During festivals, we gathered with the other candle-bearers within disused tool rooms, or in the corners of empty halls, lighting the dark like a sea of fireflies.

After several long years, the servant died. By this point, we only discussed matters relating to our candles. We would fret over whether we'd juiced the wick with too much oil; we would fret when the wick looked dry, and diminish with the waning flame. During these discussions, the servant would not speak. When we would ask him his thoughts, he would call us foolish for sharing our secrets, that he had found the right way to go about it but would not share. We found him in his room. Having been too impatient with the wick, he had juiced it too much. Over time the flame had seared his belly, and he was dead.

Others, outside our group, died before their candles went out. On the fifth year, we had stopped talking entirely, but still kept each other's company. We would wander through the lavish hallways, rest beneath staircases, heads bent in singular focus, whispering to the flame, caressing the edges of its warmth. One night, the minister of culture, unthinking, rolled over while sleeping, snuffing out his flame. He and the jester had remained especially close; they were the only two who still talked. At the sight of him being carried away, the jester was driven instantly mad.

In the seventh year, I could take no more. I had stopped taking the ointment they gave us for belt rash. When I closed my eyes, I could see the brilliant shimmer of the flame pressed into the dark, so that I could no longer look away. Four months stretched between when I decided to let go before I finally gave up. One night, I woke up to a searing heat. The candleflame had

begun to burn my belly and I was terrified that, like the servant before me, I too might die. But still I only knew the candle, thought only in terms of breeze and heat. Panicked, I doused the wick in oil and the whole thing went up at once. The candle had melted. I still have the scars from the wax, but I was otherwise alive.

The punishment for failure is severe. It is not to be condemned to rot away in the dungeons or hung on the gallows, for there are none. In fact, there is no judicial system, nor are there courtrooms, or jails, in a single province in all of the Border Prince territories. I was sentenced alongside all of those found breaking the law, which are singularly few: murder without consent, conspiring with another prince, gross acts of violence or debauchery. We were cast out of the border prince's fiefdom; our names stricken from the book in black-ink; excommunicated, we were never permitted to return again. The reason follows from the principles that govern the princes' rule: to be made to leave in such a manner, not of one's own volition and waning desire, but against one's own will, stains the consciousness in perpetuity. To prevent another from attaining something, as opposed to them denying that thing themselves, is effectively equivalent to unrecognizing someone as conscious by revoking their agency. Attain self-fulfillment, or despair and wail, the excommunicated has had the walls of possibility closed in on them.

Unpersoned, many cannot cope. They wander along the rolling walkways, a black mark trailing their conscience like a stray dog. Slowly driven mad by the prospect of a banded universe, they will take up posts along the crossroads, howling like grief-stricken banshees, waiting for travelers so that they can return to the beginning of their tragic tale.